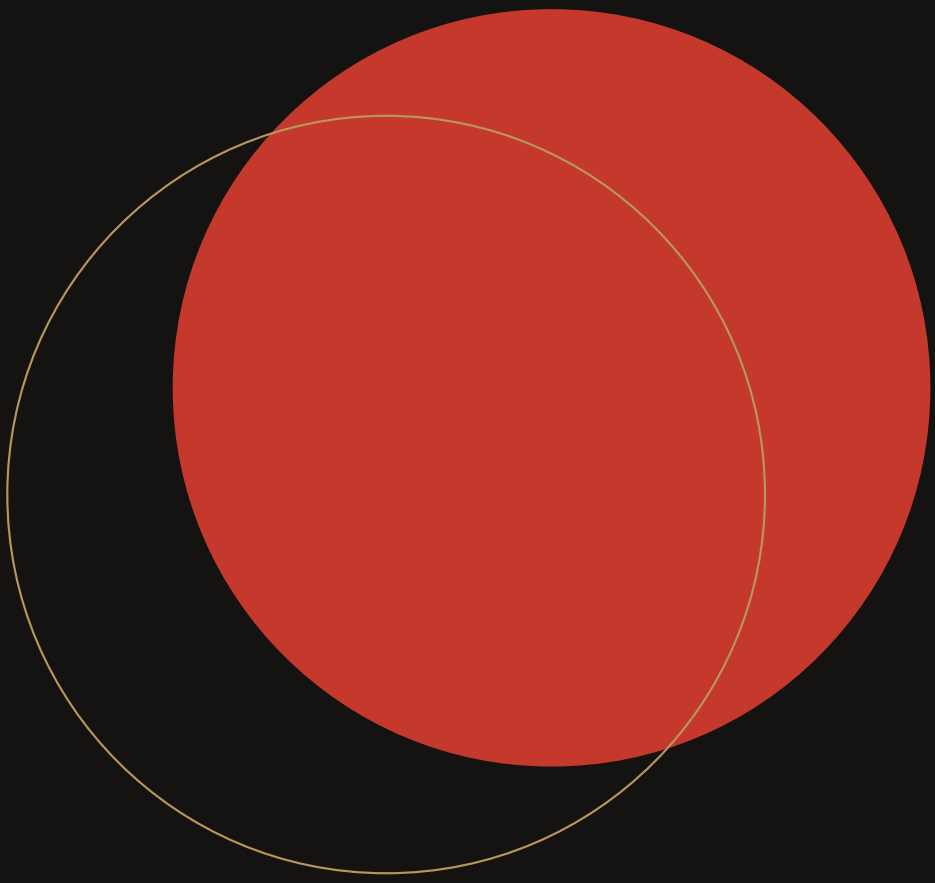
豊饒の海



A DOCTORAL THESIS IN COMPARATIVE LITERATURE AND PHILOSOPHY

The Copy That *Bleeds*

Yukio Mishima, the Sengū Hypothesis, and the Speculative Ontology of Posthistorical Tragedy

COMPARATIVE LITERATURE · PHILOSOPHY

2026

The Copy That Bleeds

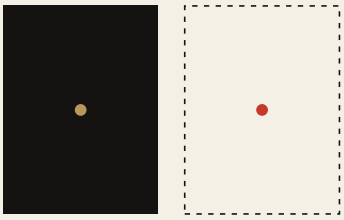


SENGŪ · THE REMOVAL OF THE SHRINE

A DOCTORAL THESIS IN COMPARATIVE LITERATURE AND PHILOSOPHY

The Copy That *Bleeds*

Yukio Mishima, the Sengū Hypothesis, and the Speculative Ontology of Posthistorical Tragedy



ISE · THE STANDING SHRINE AND THE VACANT PLOT

SEPTEMBER 2026

FRONT MATTER

Abstract

This thesis reads the novels, plays, essays, films, and final public act of Mishima Yukio (1925–1970) as a single speculative experiment on the ontology of form, and argues that the experiment was falsified by its own author on the morning of its final trial. Against the biographical, psychoanalytic, political, queer-theoretical, and cultural-essentialist paradigms that have governed Mishima studies—each of which, by different routes, makes the death of 25 November 1970 the hermeneutic key to the oeuvre—it proposes the inverse: that the oeuvre is the key to the death, and a more severe one than either the death's admirers or its detractors have recognised. The works, it contends, formulate, test, and ultimately refute a metaphysical proposition here designated the *sengū hypothesis*: the wager, made explicit in *Bunka bōeiron* (1968) through the paradigm of the twenty-yearly ritual reconstruction (*shikinen sengū*) of the Grand Shrine of Ise, that a form may be perpetuated through the periodic destruction and renewal of its material bearer without loss of authenticity, so that copy and original become ontologically indiscernible.

Part I reconstructs the genealogy of the hypothesis across four source-traditions: the confessional and aestheticist lineage (Augustine, Rousseau, Wilde, Huysmans, D'Annunzio, Mann), whose inversion in *Kamen no kokuhaku* (*Confessions of a Mask*, 1949) establishes what the thesis terms *iconic anteriority*, the constitutive priority of image over body, word over flesh, and mask over face; the Nietzschean and Hellenic cult of the surface, as mediated by the Japan Romantic School; the martial-metaphysical syncretism of *Hagakure*, Yōmeigaku, Rinzai Zen, and Shintō nativism, which grounds action in a void; and the Bataillean and Sadean economy of transgression and sovereign expenditure. Part II offers close readings of *Kinkakuji* (*The Temple of the Golden Pavilion*, 1956), *Taiyō to tetsu* (*Sun and Steel*, 1968), and the Emperor-essays, and argues that Mishima's doctrine of beauty as barrier, his somatic turn, and his theory of the Emperor as a cultural concept together compose a *thanatoplastic* programme: the sculpting of the living body toward its terminal, monumental visibility. Part III situates the corpus within twentieth-century speculative and philosophical fiction (Lem, Bioy Casares, Borges, Dick, Le Guin, Stapledon, Clarke, Vonnegut, Huxley,

Hesse, Kafka, Ballard, Abe Kōbō, Komatsu Sakyō, Murakami Haruki) and contends that *Utsukushii hoshi* (*Beautiful Star*, 1962) and the tetralogy *Hōjō no umi* (*The Sea of Fertility*, 1965–1970) constitute a distinctively Buddhist-nativist contribution to the ontological turn in speculative fiction, one whose reincarnations, each expiring at twenty, stage the Ise cycle as narrative form.

The final chapter demonstrates that the tetralogy's closing page—delivered on the morning of 25 November 1970 and set in a future its author had resolved not to inhabit—falsifies the sengū hypothesis by disclosing a chain of copies without an original, and that the Ichigaya act of the same day must therefore be read as an attempt to produce what the novel had just declared impossible: *a copy that bleeds*, a representation coincident with the real. Drawing on Kojève's posthistorical "snobbery," Deleuze's simulacrum, Baudrillard's symbolic exchange, Danto's indiscernibles, Barthes's empty centre, and Schopenhauer's analysis of suicide as an affirmation of the will, the thesis names this double structure *posthistorical tragedy*: tragic action undertaken in full foreknowledge that it will be received as its own replica. It concludes that Mishima's fiction contains the most rigorous refutation of his act, and that this self-refutation, rather than the act, constitutes his lasting contribution to the philosophy of literature.

FRONT MATTER

Note on Conventions and Sources

Japanese personal names appear surname first (Mishima Yukio, Kawabata Yasunari, Ōe Kenzaburō), except in the title, which uses the form under which the author is internationally catalogued, and in citations of Western-language publications that reverse the order. Romanisation follows modified Hepburn; macrons are retained except in familiar place-names (Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka). Japanese titles are romanised at first mention with the year of first book publication, followed by the title of the standard English translation where one exists; thereafter the English title is used. References to Mishima's Japanese texts are to the *Ketteiban Mishima Yukio zenshū* (Shinchōsha, 2000–2006). Sanskrit follows IAST; Chinese follows pinyin, with Japanese readings supplied where the Japanese reception is at issue (Wang Yangming / Ō Yōmei; Linji / Rinzai).

Because the object of analysis is a structure of thought rather than a verbal texture, and because Mishima's texts and their translations remain in copyright, the corpus is paraphrased rather than quoted, save where a phrase has acquired terminological status (*bunbu ryōdō*, *kitaikyo*, *bunka gainen to shite no tennō*). Sources in the public domain (Plato, the *Taiheiki*, *Hagakure*, Nietzsche, Wagner, the German text of Benjamin) are occasionally cited in the original. All translations of phrases are the author's own. Claims of influence are advanced only where Mishima's reading is documented; elsewhere the comparative method is explicitly structural, identifying homologous solutions to shared problems rather than lines of descent.

The thesis treats the events of 25 November 1970, including the wounding of Self-Defense Force officers and the deaths of Mishima and Morita Masakatsu, as historical and textual facts to be analysed rather than as models to be admired. Its argument, made explicit in the final chapter, is that Mishima's own corpus supplies the most exacting critique of those events.

THE THESIS

Contents

	Abstract	4
	Note on Conventions and Sources	6
	Seven Concepts	8
0	Introduction *The Last Page and the Last Act*	9
PART I · GENEALOGIES		16
1	Iconic Anteriority *Confession, Mask, and the Originary Supplement*	17
2	Greek Surfaces, German Depths *Nietzsche, Mann, Decadence, and the Japan Romantic School*	23
3	The Sword and the Void Hagakure, *Yōmeigaku, Zen, and Shintō Nativism*	29
4	Eros, Transgression, Expenditure *Bataille, Sade, and the Liebestod*	35
PART II · STRUCTURES		40
5	Beauty as Barrier The Temple of the Golden Pavilion	41
6	*Sun and Steel* *The Somatic Turn and Thanatoplasty*	46
7	The Emperor as Empty Centre *Culture*, Kokutai, *and the Death of God*	52
PART III · SPECULATIONS		58
8	Epitaphic Humanism Beautiful Star *and the Cosmic Gaze*	59
9	The Storehouse and the Ocean The Sea of Fertility *as Speculative Ontology*	64
10	The Last Instant *Glory, Nihilism, and the Speculative Moment*	73
11	The Copy That Bleeds *Toward a Theory of Posthistorical Tragedy*	79
—	Conclusion *The Garden at Noon*	87
	Works Cited	90
	Keywords	96

THE ARGUMENT

Seven Concepts

1 **Iconic anteriority** — CH. 1

The image precedes the body, the word the flesh, the mask the face.

2 **Thanatoplasty** — CHS. 4, 6

The sculpting of the living body toward its terminal, monumental visibility.

3 **The sengū hypothesis** — CHS. 7, 9

Form persists through, and only through, the periodic destruction of its bearer.

4 **Epitaphic humanism** — CH. 8

Humanity loved only as already extinct: a completed form seen from outside history.

5 **Speculative ontology** — 0.4, CH. 9

Narratives as controlled experiments on being, certified by their material consequences.

6 **The copy that bleeds** — CHS. 9, 11

A representation that coincides with what it represents: an icon that is also an index.

7 **Posthistorical tragedy** — CH. 11

Tragic action undertaken in full foreknowledge that it will be received as its own replica.

INTRODUCTION

The Last Page and the Last Act

序

0.1

The Double Ending of 25 November 1970

On the morning of 25 November 1970 Mishima Yukio left at his house in Magome, sealed for collection by his Shinchōsha editor Kojima Chiaki, the final instalment of *Tennin gosui* (*The Decay of the Angel*), the fourth and closing volume of *Hōjō no umi* (*The Sea of Fertility*). The last leaf of the manuscript carries that day's date, a date which, on the balance of the biographical record, marks the consignment of the text rather than its composition. Some hours later, accompanied by four members of the Tatenokai, the private militia he had founded in 1968, he entered the Eastern Army headquarters of the Ground Self-Defense Force at Ichigaya, took the commanding general, Mashita Kanetoshi, hostage and bound him to his chair. When officers forced their way into the office to free him, Mishima drove them back with his sword, wounding several of them, and then demanded, under threat of killing the general, that the garrison be assembled before the building. At noon he addressed from the balcony a crowd of soldiers who could scarcely hear him beneath the rotors of press helicopters and who answered him with jeers. The appeal, restated in the manifesto *Geki* scattered from the same balcony, called on the Self-Defense Forces to rise for the revision of the postwar Constitution and the restoration of the Emperor to the centre of the national order. It lasted a few minutes. Mishima then withdrew into the general's office and, in the presence of the bound general, committed

seppuku. Morita Masakatsu, the militia's student leader, acting as his second (kaishakunin), failed to complete the beheading that the rite prescribes; another member, Koga Hiroyasu, completed it. Morita then committed seppuku and was beheaded by Koga. The three surviving members surrendered and were later convicted and imprisoned.

The day therefore produced two endings, and the conjunction of those endings is the object of this thesis. The first is textual. In the closing chapter of *The Decay of the Angel* the eighty-one-year-old Honda Shigekuni, witness and chronicler of the tetralogy's four incarnations, travels to the Gesshūji convent near Nara to see Satoko, the beloved of the first incarnation, Matsugae Kiyoaki, and now the abbess. She receives him with perfect courtesy and professes no knowledge of Kiyoaki whatsoever; she wonders aloud whether such a person ever existed, and extends the doubt, gently, to Honda himself. She then leads him into the convent's south garden, empty in the glare of a summer noon and loud with cicadas, and Honda understands that he has arrived at a place without memory, where there is nothing. The chronology of the fiction is not incidental. The last volume opens in 1970 and closes in the summer of 1975, so that the final page of Mishima's final work is a near-future narrative, a speculative fiction in the most literal sense, set in a world its author had arranged not to inhabit.

The second ending is enacted. It is a death constructed, across more than a decade of rehearsal in prose, photograph, film, and drill, to mean something that could not be mistaken for fiction. The first ending declares that the chain of transmission on which the tetralogy rests—four lives, each closing at or near twenty, linked by a mark on the body and by the testimony of a single witness—leads to no original and returns nothing. The second attempts to produce, in the most unrepeatable register available to a human being, an event that would be its own original. The one is a negation, articulated in the vocabulary of Hossō Buddhism; the other an affirmation, articulated in the vocabulary of *Hagakure* and the loyalist dead. The one was written first, the other performed after. What this sequence implies, if the order of composition is taken as seriously as Mishima took the order of all things, is the question from which every subsequent chapter departs.

0.2

Six Paradigms and Their Common Presupposition

The scholarship may be sorted into six paradigms, each of which has produced indispensable work. The *biographical* paradigm, inaugurated in a single year by John Nathan's *Mishima: A Biography* (1974) and Henry Scott Stokes's *The Life and Death of Yukio Mishima* (1974), refined in Inose Naoki and Hiroaki Sato's *Persona* (2012), and condensed in Damian Flanagan's *Yukio Mishima* (2014), reconstructs the life as a trajectory whose terminus organises its episodes. The *psychoanalytic and psychohistorical* paradigm, represented by Robert Jay Lifton, Katō Shūichi, and Michael Reich's *Six Lives/Six Deaths* (1979) and Jerry Piven's *The Madness and Perversion of Yukio Mishima* (2004), reads the oeuvre as the symptomatic record of a death drive, a narcissistic formation, or a generational wound opened in 1945. The *political* paradigm divides between the hagiography of the nationalist right, ritualised in the annual Yūkokuki memorial, and a critical tradition that measures Mishima against Maruyama Masao's anatomy of ultranationalism (1946), situates him in the genealogy of fascist aesthetics reconstructed by Alan Tansman (2009), or, in Andrew Rankin's formula, portrays him as an aesthetic terrorist (2018). The *queer-theoretical* paradigm, exemplified by Keith Vincent's reading of *Kamen no kokuhaku* in *Two-Timing Modernity* (2012) and informed by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's epistemology of the closet, discloses homosocial and homosexual structures that earlier criticism either pathologised or passed over. The *aesthetic-comparative* paradigm—Masao Miyoshi's *Accomplices of Silence* (1974), Gwenn Boardman Petersen's *The Moon in the Water* (1979), Marguerite Yourcenar's *Mishima ou la vision du vide* (1980), Donald Keene's *Dawn to the West* (1984), Susan Napier's *Escape from the Wasteland* (1991), and Roy Starrs's *Deadly Dialectics* (1994)—locates the works within the modern Japanese novel and within the European traditions of aestheticism and nihilism. The *cultural-essentialist* paradigm, finally, treats Mishima as an avatar of an imputed samurai essence disclosed to a Western audience. It is the paradigm Mishima himself cultivated before foreign cameras, and its structural premise survives even in so intelligent a screen treatment as Paul Schrader's *Mishima: A Life in Four Chapters* (1985), whose chapters—Beauty, Art, Action, Harmony of Pen and Sword—arrange the works as stations on the road to Ichigaya.

These paradigms disagree about nearly everything except the direction of explanation. Each treats the death as the key and the works as the lock: prelude, rehearsal, symptom, alibi, or ideological preparation. The

present argument stands closest to Ōsawa Masachi's insistence (2018) that the manner of the death and the self-annulling ending of the tetralogy constitute twin riddles to be solved together, and it shares with Hirano Keiichirō's monumental *Mishima Yukio ron* (2023) a commitment to reading the major works as sustained philosophical argument. It differs from both in the apparatus by which it resolves the riddles and in the direction of explanation it adopts. It reads the works as the key and the act as the lock, and it argues that the key does not fit: that the corpus, taken as a system of propositions about form, representation, and the body, predicts the failure of the act more exactly than any external critique, because its author had already conducted on paper the experiment he would conduct at Ichigaya.

0.3

The Argument: Seven Concepts

The inversion requires a vocabulary. The thesis proposes seven concepts, defined here and developed in the chapters indicated.

Iconic anteriority (Chapter 1) names the constitutive priority, in Mishima's self-description and throughout his fiction, of image over body, word over flesh, and mask over face. The first erotic experience recorded in *Confessions of a Mask* is occasioned not by a body but by a reproduction of a painting; *Sun and Steel* opens with the avowal that words preceded flesh; and the adult life unfolds beneath a death imagined in 1945, prepared for, and then withheld. The image is not the copy of an experience but its condition of possibility.

Thanatoplasty (Chapters 4 and 6), from *thanatos* and *plassein*, to mould, names the practice of sculpting the living body toward its terminal, monumental visibility: the bodybuilding begun in 1955; the photographic collaborations with Hosoe Eikō (*Barakei*, 1963) and Shinoyama Kishin, including the Sebastian of 1968 and the staged deaths of *Otoko no shi* (1970), withheld from publication for half a century; the filmed seppuku of *Yūkoku* (1966); and finally the event of 1970, understood as the completion of a monument in which sculptor and stone were meant to coincide.

The *sengū hypothesis* (Chapters 7 and 9) names the metaphysical proposition articulated in *Bunka bōeiron* (*In Defence of Culture*, 1968): that the Grand Shrine of Ise, rebuilt every twenty years on an adjacent plot from fresh materials in the rite of *shikinen sengū*, demonstrates a conception of culture in which the copy is the original, because form persists

through, and only through, the periodic destruction of its material bearer. The thesis argues that *The Sea of Fertility*, whose successive protagonists die at or near twenty, is the narrative transposition of this proposition—an Ise cycle made of persons—and that the tetralogy is its trial.

Epitaphic humanism (Chapter 8) names the stance, formulated in the extraterrestrial epitaph for mankind in *Utsukushii hoshi* (*Beautiful Star*, 1962), in which the human is loved only as already extinct: humanity valued as a completed form, visible from outside history, precisely as the Golden Pavilion is valued by the acolyte who will burn it.

Speculative ontology (0.4 and Chapter 9) names the method of the thesis and, it will be argued, the method of Mishima's major fiction: the construction of narratives as controlled experiments on being, in which the novum is not a technology but a metaphysical premise, and in which reality is certified by its material consequences.

The copy that bleeds (Chapters 9 and 11) names the object toward which the corpus strives and which it finally declares impossible: a representation that coincides with what it represents, an icon that is also an index, a replica that becomes an original because it suffers.

Posthistorical tragedy (Chapter 11) names the form that action assumes when tragedy is attempted under the conditions Alexandre Kojève, in the famous note added to the second edition of his *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel* (1962), attributed to Japan: a condition after history, in which negating action has been replaced by formalised snobbery and even the gratuitous suicide has become a form. Posthistorical tragedy is tragic action undertaken in full foreknowledge that it will be received as its own replica.

The central claim may now be stated. *The Sea of Fertility* formulates the sengū hypothesis as narrative and falsifies it on its final page, where the chain of copies is shown to lack an original and the witness finds, at its terminus, an empty garden. The Ichigaya act, performed on the day of delivery, is an attempt to produce precisely what the novel had just declared impossible: a copy that bleeds. The fiction therefore constitutes the most rigorous refutation of the act, and the order of the two—refutation first, experiment after—defines the structure of posthistorical tragedy. The double ending also possesses a philosophical grammar. The text concludes in the idiom of Buddhist and Schopenhauerian negation; the act, in the idiom of Nietzschean and *Hagakure* affirmation. Yet Schopenhauer had already argued, in §69 of *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* (1819), that suicide, far from denying the will, is one of its most

emphatic affirmations, since the suicide wills life and quarrels only with the conditions on which it is offered. Read with Schopenhauer, the text is the more radical negation and the act the more conventional affirmation—an inversion of the very hierarchy the act was designed to impose.

0.4

Method: Speculative Ontology and the Spinning Charcoal Scuttle

The comparative frame is supplied by the theory of speculative fiction, reoriented. Darko Suvin defined science fiction as the literature of cognitive estrangement, organised around a novum whose strangeness is validated by cognitive logic (*Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*, 1979). Tzvetan Todorov located the fantastic in the reader's hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation (*Introduction à la littérature fantastique*, 1970). Brian McHale argued that postmodernist fiction is governed by an ontological rather than an epistemological dominant, and that science fiction is the ontological genre par excellence (*Postmodernist Fiction*, 1987). Fredric Jameson, finally, read the genre's futures as instruments for estranging the present (*Archaeologies of the Future*, 2005). Mishima's tetralogy occupies a position none of these accounts anticipates. Its novum, reincarnation, is neither a technological extrapolation nor an object of Todorovian hesitation. It is a hypothesis subjected to trial: its investigator is a magistrate trained in the law of evidence; its data are three moles beneath the left armpit, a dream diary, and a sequence of deaths at twenty; and its theoretical apparatus, set out at length in *Akatsuki no tera* (*The Temple of Dawn*, 1970), is the Yogācāra analysis of consciousness. The cognitive logic that validates the novum is Buddhist epistemology rather than natural science, and the result is a speculative fiction whose object is not a possible world but the structure of identity across discontinuity—the relation of form to matter and of copy to original.

Mishima supplied his own criterion for such fiction. In *Shōsetsu to wa nani ka* (*What Is the Novel?*, serialised 1968–1970, published 1972) he dwells on the twenty-second tale of Yanagita Kunio's *Tōno monogatari* (1910), in which the ghost of a dead old woman passes through the room where her wake is being kept and the hem of her kimono brushes a round charcoal scuttle, which is set spinning. The novel, Mishima argues, exists at exactly this point: the apparition is made real not by its appearance but by the trivial, physical, causally continuous consequence it produces.

Reality in fiction is certified by the scuttle, not by the ghost. The thesis generalises this criterion into a method. In each work it seeks the charcoal scuttle—the minimal material consequence by which a metaphysical premise is converted into fact—and asks what that consequence proves. In *Kinkakuji* the scuttle is the fire; in *Beautiful Star*, the saucer whose arrival is promised and deferred; in the tetralogy, the moles. And the act of 25 November, on this reading, is the attempt to set spinning the charcoal scuttle of the world itself, to extend the criterion of fictional reality from the page to history by producing a consequence that no reader could dismiss as literature.

Where Mishima's reading is documented—Nietzsche, Mann, Wilde, Radiguet, D'Annunzio, Bataille, *Hagakure*, Wang Yangming, the Yogācāra treatises, the Japan Romantic School—the thesis traces lines of descent. Elsewhere, and especially in Part III, its comparisons are explicitly structural: Lem, Bioy Casares, Borges, Dick, Le Guin, Stapledon, Clarke, Vonnegut, Huxley, and Hesse are adduced not as sources but as independent solutions to the problems Mishima set himself, whose divergences from his solutions are as instructive as their convergences.

0.5

Plan of the Thesis

Part I, *Genealogies*, reconstructs the four traditions from which the sengū hypothesis was assembled: the confessional and aestheticist lineage whose inversion in *Confessions of a Mask* establishes iconic anteriority (Chapter 1); the Nietzschean cult of the surface and its Japanese mediation through the Japan Romantic School (Chapter 2); the martial metaphysics of *Hagakure*, Yōmeigaku, Rinzai Zen, and Shintō nativism, which grounds action in a void (Chapter 3); and the Bataillean and Sadean economy of transgression and expenditure (Chapter 4). Part II, *Structures*, reads *Kinkakuji* as the first trial of the hypothesis, conducted in the presence of a reconstructed temple (Chapter 5); *Sun and Steel* as the manifesto of thanatoplasty (Chapter 6); and the Emperor-essays as a political theology of the empty centre (Chapter 7). Part III, *Speculations*, situates *Beautiful Star* among the cosmic fictions of Stapledon, Clarke, and Vonnegut (Chapter 8); reads *The Sea of Fertility* as speculative ontology alongside Lem, Bioy Casares, Borges, Le Guin, and Dick (Chapter 9); examines the aesthetics of the last instant in the plays and shorter fiction (Chapter 10); and assembles, in Chapter 11, the theory of posthistorical tragedy. The Conclusion returns to the garden at noon.

PART I

Genealogies

The four traditions from which the sengū hypothesis was assembled.

01 Iconic Anteriority

02 Greek Surfaces, German Depths

03 The Sword and the Void

04 Eros, Transgression, Expenditure

CHAPTER ONE

Iconic Anteriority

Confession, Mask, and the Originary Supplement

1.1 The Paradox of the Confessing Mask

The Western genre of confession rests on a topology of depth. From Augustine's *Confessiones* (c. 397–400) to Rousseau's *Confessions* (1782–1789), the confessing subject descends beneath appearances to a truth that precedes its utterance: before God, in Augustine; before a reading public constituted as tribunal, in Rousseau, whose opening boast of an enterprise without precedent is at once a claim to exemplary sincerity and the founding gesture of modern self-publicity. Karatani Kōjin's *Nihon kindai bungaku no kigen* (1980; *Origins of Modern Japanese Literature*, 1993) demonstrated that this topology arrived in Meiji Japan not as a discovery but as an institution. Confession, Karatani argues, is a system that produces the interiority it purports to reveal; the naturalist scandal of Tayama Katai's *Futon* (1907) and the *shishōsetsu* that followed it did not expose hidden selves but manufactured the hiddenness that made exposure meaningful.

Kamen no kokuhaku (1949) turns this institution against itself with a title that is a logical trap. If the mask confesses, what it confesses is a mask; if the confession concerns masks, the confession is itself one. The novel honours both readings. Its narrator recounts the years in which he learned to perform a normative heterosexual masculinity, and the performance he describes is indistinguishable from the performance of describing it; the book was read at once, and was designed to be read, as the au-

tobiography of the young Hiraoka Kimitake, who had published under the name Mishima Yukio since 1941. In a note accompanying the first edition Mishima called the book a testament addressed to the domain of death in which he had until then resided, and characterised its writing as a kind of suicide turned inside out. The formula is exact. The confession does not bring a hidden life into the light; it inters a life that had been lived as a death, and it does so by constructing, in public, the mask behind which a survivor may continue.

1.2

The Primal Scene: Reni's Sebastian

The novel opens with a claim that the adults around the narrator find absurd: that he remembers the scene of his own birth, and in particular a glint of light on the rim of the basin in which he was first bathed. The first memory is an image without an experiencer, a gleam that precedes the subject who will claim it. Everything that follows elaborates this priority. The child of four is seized by the figure of a night-soil man descending a slope in close-fitting work trousers, and the emotion he records is not desire for the man but a longing to become him, attached to a word—*tragic*—which designates a life from which the child feels himself constitutively excluded. He treasures a picture-book illustration of a knight on horseback until he is told that the knight is Joan of Arc, a woman, whereupon he never opens the book again. He dresses in his grandmother's kimono to impersonate the stage magician Shōkyokusai Tenkatsu. In each case desire takes as its object not a body but a figure already framed, costumed, and destined: a role within a tragedy the child is not permitted to perform.

The decisive scene occurs at twelve. Kept home from school, the narrator leafs through an album of reproductions his father has brought from abroad and arrives at Guido Reni's *Saint Sebastian*, the version in the Palazzo Rosso at Genoa: the youth bound to a tree, his arms raised, pierced by arrows, his face turned upward in an expression the narrator reads as melancholy pleasure. The account culminates in the narrator's first ejaculation, recorded under the Latin term *ejaculatio* as if clinical vocabulary could hold the event at a distance, and followed by the citation of Magnus Hirschfeld's observation that pictures of Sebastian rank high among the artworks favoured by inverts. Three features of the scene govern the entire corpus. The object of desire is an image, not a body; the image is a reproduction, a copy of a painting that is itself a representation

of a legend; and the body within the image is a body at the threshold of death, whose beauty is inseparable from its wounding. Eros is constituted, from its first appearance, as a relation to an icon of martyrdom. The subject does not first desire and then find images to represent desire; desire is the effect of the image, and what the image offers is death made visible.

1.3

The Originary Supplement: Rousseau, Derrida, Lacan, Riviere

In *De la grammatologie* (1967) Jacques Derrida read Rousseau's phrase for masturbation—the dangerous supplement—as the key to a logic in which that which is added to a presumed plenitude reveals that the plenitude was lacking from the start: writing supplements speech, the image supplements presence, and the supplement turns out to be originary. The Sebastian scene is the dangerous supplement in Rousseau's literal sense, and it confirms Derrida's argument with a rigour Rousseau could not permit himself. There is no prior presence that the image supplements. The reproduction does not substitute for an absent body; it inaugurates the sexuality that will afterwards seek bodies to resemble it. This is iconic anteriority in its strongest form: the copy precedes the original, and the original, when it arrives, is received as a copy of the copy.

The same year in which *Kamen no kokuhaku* appeared, Jacques Lacan delivered at Zurich the definitive version of his paper on the mirror stage (1949), which describes the ego as formed through identification with an external image that anticipates a bodily unity the infant does not yet possess. The *imago* is orthopaedic: it supplies in advance a totality the body must then labour to attain, and it installs alienation at the root of identity. Mishima's biography reads as a literalisation of the Lacanian scheme. The imago of the martyred youth anticipates a body the sickly adolescent does not have; the bodybuilding begun in 1955 is the orthopaedic realisation of that anticipation; and the photograph Shinoyama Kishin took in 1968, of Mishima bound and pierced in the pose of Reni's Sebastian, closes the circle, since the man who at twelve desired an image now becomes a copy of it. Yet the closure is imperfect in a way that will prove decisive. A photograph of a pose remains a representation of a representation. The arrows are props, and nothing bleeds.

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) supplied the psychoanalytic formula that the novel's treatment of gender presupposes.

Riviere's patient adopts an exaggerated femininity as a defensive mask, and Riviere concludes that no line can be drawn between such masquerade and genuine womanliness: they are the same thing. Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) radicalised the point into a theory of performativity in which gender is an imitation without an origin, a copy whose supposed original is itself produced by the iteration of copies. *Kamen no kokuhaku* had drawn the corresponding conclusion for masculinity four decades earlier. The narrator's courtship of Sonoko, conducted by the rules of a normativity he studies like a foreign grammar, culminates in a kiss in which he feels nothing, and the novel's quiet scandal is the suggestion that his performance differs from the performances of others only in being conscious. The mask is not a lie laid over a truth; the mask is the general form of the social face, and the narrator's distinction is that he knows it.

Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's analysis of the closet as a regime of knowledge (*Epistemology of the Closet*, 1990), organised around the open secret that is known and not acknowledged, clarifies the novel's public situation. Published under a pen name that everyone could penetrate, marketed as fiction and received as autobiography, *Kamen no kokuhaku* is an open secret addressed to an entire readership. Keith Vincent has read it against the developmental temporality through which Japanese modernity figured male homosociality as a stage to be outgrown, and has shown how its sexological apparatus both borrows and ironises that narrative. The present thesis adds a structural observation. The closet in Mishima is not a space in which a true self hides behind a false one; it is a space in which the self is constituted as the relation between two masks, neither of which is a face. The ending of the novel, in which the narrator's gaze is divided between Sonoko and a half-naked young labourer in a dance hall whom he imagines stabbed, does not resolve into disclosure. It suspends the subject between two images, each of which he can only regard.

1.4
Masks Elsewhere: Wilde, Pirandello, Abe Kōbō

Oscar Wilde provides the aesthetic doctrine of which iconic anteriority is the psychological consequence. In "The Decay of Lying" (1889) Vivian insists that "Life imitates Art far more than Art imitates Life"; in "The Critic as Artist" (1891) Gilbert observes that man is least himself when he talks in his own person, and that given a mask he will tell the truth. *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890–1891) is the fable in which the principle is tested to de-

struction. The portrait bears the body's history while the face remains a mask of youth, and when Dorian stabs the canvas it is the man who dies: the servants find the painting restored to its original beauty and, on the floor, a withered corpse. Wilde's fable is the first figure in this thesis of the copy that bleeds, and it is instructive that it takes the form of a reversal. The image and the body exchange places at the moment of violence; they do not coincide.

Luigi Pirandello's *Uno, nessuno e centomila* (1926) takes the mask in the opposite direction. Vitangelo Moscarda's discovery that his nose inclines to one side, a fact visible to everyone but himself, dissolves him into the hundred thousand Moscardas who exist in others' perceptions, and the novel ends with his renunciation of identity altogether and a life without a name, renewed from moment to moment in the flux of nature. Where Pirandello's solution to the plurality of masks is dispersion, Mishima's will be consolidation: not the refusal of the mask but its hardening into a single image, fixed by death. Abe Kōbō's *Tanin no kao* (*The Face of Another*, 1964), a contemporaneous meditation on the same problem, offers a third solution. Its scientist-narrator, his face destroyed by keloid scarring, fabricates a lifelike prosthetic mask and uses it to seduce his own wife, only to learn from her letter that she recognised him from the first and had consented to the masquerade. For Abe, the face is a road between persons, and no mask can escape the other's knowledge; identity is social and epistemic. For Mishima, the face is precisely what the mask has replaced, and the other's knowledge is irrelevant to the ontological question of what, behind the mask, remains.

1.5

The Missed Death and the Posthumous Life

Iconic anteriority has a temporal as well as an erotic dimension, and its temporal form is the missed death. The young Hiraoka graduated at the head of his class at the Gakushūin in 1944 and received a silver watch from the Emperor; he entered the law faculty of Tokyo Imperial University in a war whose ideology had taught his generation to regard death at twenty as the natural consummation of youth. His literary name was itself anterior to his public person: it was devised in 1941, when his teacher Shimizu Fumio arranged the publication of *Hanazakari no mori* (*The Forest in Full Bloom*) in the coterie journal *Bungei bunka*, whose circle included the nationalist poet-scholar Hasuda Zenmei, and it was adopted in part to shield the schoolboy from his father's disapproval.

Mishima Yukio was a mask before he was a face. In February 1945, called for his conscription physical with a fever, he was misdiagnosed by an army doctor with the onset of a pulmonary illness, did not contest the diagnosis, and was sent home. *Kamen no kokuhaku* renders the episode as a flight from the barracks in which relief and shame are inseparable.

The consequence was a life lived after its own imagined end. The death of 1945 had been anticipated in image—in the aesthetics of the falling cherry blossom, in the rhetoric of the Special Attack Corps, in a literature of youthful sacrifice—and it had been withheld. The image of death therefore preceded not only the death but the life that followed, which acquired, in the retrospective essays of the 1960s, the character of an extension never willed. Roland Barthes, in *La Chambre claire* (1980), identified in Alexander Gardner's photograph of the condemned conspirator Lewis Payne the catastrophic tense of photography, in which the subject is at once already dead and still about to die. Mishima's postwar existence was lived in that tense. For twenty-five years he inhabited the interval of a long exposure, between an image of death already fixed and an event that would, if it came, merely develop it.

The chapter's conclusion can be stated as the first premise of the sengū hypothesis. If the image precedes the body, then the body is the replica of an image, and the only path by which the replica can attain the dignity of an original is to become an image in its turn—to die into its picture. The whole of Mishima's subsequent development may be read as the search for the conditions under which this conversion could be accomplished without remainder: under which the copy would cease to be a pose, and the arrows would draw blood.

CHAPTER TWO

Greek Surfaces, German Depths

Nietzsche, Mann, Decadence, and the Japan Romantic School

2.1 The Journey to the Surface

Between December 1951 and May 1952 Mishima travelled as a special correspondent of the *Asahi shinbun* through the Americas and Europe, and the account he published on his return, *Aporo no sakazuki* (*Apollo's Cup*, 1952), locates the crisis of the journey in Greece. What the Acropolis revealed, on his telling, was a civilisation that had not yet invented the invisible spirit: a culture in which body and intellect stood in equilibrium, in which beauty was an external and visible property, and in which the ethical ideal was the preservation of that equilibrium rather than the cultivation of an interior. The young novelist who had made his name by the confession of a mask returned resolved to cure himself of romanticism by classicism, to become, as it were, all surface. *Shiosai* (*The Sound of Waves*, 1954), a transposition of Longus's *Daphnis and Chloe* to the fishing island of Kamishima—renamed Utajima—at the mouth of Ise Bay, is the programmatic result: a pastoral of perfect health in which the lovers possess no interiority that the landscape does not display, and in which the central erotic ordeal, the girl's command that the boy leap through the fire in the abandoned watchtower, is a trial of the body's courage rather than of the soul's sincerity.

The classicist phase was brief, and its brevity is instructive. It is significant that the novel of classical health was set within the sacred geography of Ise, in whose Grand Shrine Mishima would later locate a classicism

of a different order; and significant, too, that the Greek surface he had found in the permanence of marble would be displaced, by 1968, by a Japanese surface whose permanence depends on periodic destruction. The present chapter reconstructs the elements from which this second classicism was assembled. It argues that Mishima learned the value of surfaces from the most profound of German thinkers, and learned the value of ruin from Japanese romantics who had learned it, in turn, from German romanticism; and that the doctrine produced by this double mediation is the second premise of the sengū hypothesis.

2.2

Nietzsche: Superficial out of Profundity

Die Geburt der Tragödie (1872) offered Mishima the dialectic that would organise his self-understanding for two decades: the Apollonian principle of image, measure, and individuation against the Dionysian principle of intoxication and dissolution, and their union in Attic tragedy as the form through which the terror of existence becomes bearable. The book's most famous proposition—that only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified (*nur als aesthetisches Phänomen ist das Dasein und die Welt ewig gerechtfertigt*)—is the charter of every subsequent aestheticism, Mishima's included. Yet it was the preface to the second edition of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1887) that supplied the formula most exactly consonant with the Greek revelation of 1952. The Greeks, Nietzsche writes, understood how to live, which requires stopping courageously at the surface, the fold, the skin (*tapfer bei der Oberfläche, der Falte, der Haut stehen zu bleiben*), worshipping appearance and believing in forms, tones, and words; and he concludes that these Greeks were superficial—out of profundity (*oberflächlich – aus Tiefe!*). Paul Valéry's contemporaneous dictum in *L'Idée fixe* (1932), that what is deepest in man is his skin, reaches the same conclusion from physiology. Susan Sontag's call, in "Against Interpretation" (1964), for an erotics rather than a hermeneutics of art belongs to the same lineage and was published in the years when Mishima was converting the doctrine into a regimen.

The Japanese reception of Nietzsche had prepared three distinct Nietzsches, and Mishima's synthesis draws on all of them. Takayama Chogyū's essay on the aesthetic life ("Biteki seikatsu o ronzu", 1901) presented Nietzsche as the prophet of instinct against morality and made him the patron of a Meiji aestheticism of self-assertion. Watsuji Tetsurō's *Nīchie kenkyū* (1913), appearing two years after Ikuta Chōkō's complete

translation of *Zarathustra* (1911), presented a philosopher of self-overcoming and the will to power. Nishitani Keiji's *Nihirizumu* (1949) presented the diagnostician of European nihilism whose problem Japan had inherited and might, through the Buddhist resources of emptiness, overcome. Mishima's Nietzsche is the aesthete of the surface, the athlete of self-overcoming, and the nihilist who must manufacture values over a void. The chapters that follow will show that the third Nietzsche finally governs the other two: the surface is cultivated because nothing lies beneath it, and the body is overcome because there is no self to overcome it for.

2.3

Mann and the Visible Spirit

Thomas Mann gave Mishima the narrative form of the problem Nietzsche had stated philosophically. *Tonio Kröger* (1903) dramatises the artist's exclusion from the unreflective life of the fair-haired and ordinary, an exclusion he experiences as a love for precisely what his vocation forbids him to be—a structure that *Kamen no kokuhaku* reproduces in the narrator's worship of the unreflective delinquent Omi. *Der Tod in Venedig* (1912) supplies the metaphysics. In the Platonic reverie that Aschenbach composes on the beach, adapting the *Phaedrus*, beauty is the only form of the spiritual that can be perceived by the senses; it is therefore the artist's path to spirit, and for that very reason a path that leads through the senses to the abyss. Mann's formula becomes, in Mishima, the premise that beauty is spirit made visible and that the visibility is fatal, since what can be seen can be possessed only by the one who ceases to see. Mishima acknowledged that the style of *Kinkakuji* was an alloy of Mori Ōgai and Mann, and the claim can be extended from style to structure: the novel's acolyte is an Aschenbach whose Tadzio is a building.

The novels of the early 1950s rehearse the Mannian structure in modes borrowed from the European decadence. *Ai no kawaki* (*Thirst for Love*, 1950), modelled on François Mauriac's *Thérèse Desqueyroux* (1927), follows a widow on a suburban farm whose desire for a young gardener culminates in her killing him, as if the only consummation compatible with desire's purity were the destruction of its object. *Kinjiki* (*Forbidden Colors*, 1951–1953) divides the aesthete into two figures. The ageing novelist Hinoki Shunsuke, a Lord Henry grown bitter, directs the beautiful young Minami Yūichi, a Dorian without a portrait, as an instrument of revenge against the women who have humiliated him, and discovers that

the youth he has fashioned is a work of art he cannot possess. Shunsuke delivers a final disquisition on the incompatibility of beauty and life, takes his own life, and leaves his fortune to Yūichi. The artist dies so that the work may survive him: the first explicit statement in the corpus of the relation between maker and made that thanatoplasty will attempt to abolish.

The emblems of the European decadence confirm the pattern. In Huysmans's *À rebours* (1884) the tortoise whose shell Des Esseintes has encrusted with gems dies beneath the weight of its ornament, an allegory of the bearer sacrificed to its adornment. Wilde's *Salomé* (1891), which Mishima directed in 1960, makes the beloved's death the condition of the kiss. Gabriele D'Annunzio, whose *Il piacere* (1889) fixed the type of the aristocratic aesthete and whose occupation of Fiume (1919–1920), with its constitution naming music a fundamental institution of the state, fixed the type of the aesthete turned man of action, supplied a biographical model whose resonance Mishima did not conceal; with Ikeda Kōtarō he translated D'Annunzio's *Le Martyre de saint Sébastien* (1911), published in 1966, returning in maturity to the martyr of his adolescence. Raymond Radiguet, finally, was the model of his apprenticeship. *Tōzoku* (*Thieves*, 1948), his first full-length novel, was written in the manner of *Le Bal du comte d'Orgel* (1924), and Radiguet's own death at twenty fixed, for the wartime adolescent, the image of the genius completed by early extinction.

2.4

The Japan Romantic School: Irony and the Aesthetics of Ruin

The German depths reached Mishima a second time through the Nihon Rōmanha, the Japan Romantic School that gathered around the journal *Nihon rōmanha* (1935–1938) and its presiding critic Yasuda Yojūrō. Yasuda's *Nihon no hashi* (*Japanese Bridges*, 1936) contrasted the Roman bridge, an instrument of conquest built to endure, with the Japanese bridge, a fragile and melancholy passage whose beauty lies in its impermanence and its orientation toward the other shore. The contrast anticipates, by three decades, Mishima's contrast between Parthenon and Ise. Yasuda's central category was irony, adapted from Friedrich Schlegel, for whom irony was the permanent parabasis of the work, the artist's capacity to hover above his own creation. In Yasuda irony became something darker: a mode of affirming the lost cause because it is lost, of loving the

nation's tradition as ruin and its youth as sacrifice, and of converting the political into an aesthetic of beautiful defeat. Kevin Doak's *Dreams of Difference* (1994) has reconstructed the school's ambivalent relation to modernity, and Alan Tansman's *The Aesthetics of Japanese Fascism* (2009) has shown how such aesthetic moods could serve as the affective infrastructure of an ideology that rarely stated itself as doctrine.

Mishima's adolescence was lived in the school's orbit. The coterie that published *Hanazakari no mori* was aligned with it, and its most intense member, Hasuda Zenmei, greeted the schoolboy's work as the voice of the classical tradition reborn. In August 1945, stationed in Malaya, Hasuda shot his commanding officer, whom he accused of defeatism, and then himself. The episode, which Mishima never ceased to contemplate, is the prototype of an act whose meaning lies wholly in its form: it could change nothing, and it was performed because it could change nothing. Hashikawa Bunzō's *Nihon rōmanha hihan josetsu* (1960), written by a member of Mishima's own generation, diagnosed the school's appeal to the youth of the war years as an aestheticisation of death that had allowed them to experience their own extinction as fulfilment, and the diagnosis applies to Mishima with an exactness that Hashikawa, who would later debate him on the Emperor, fully recognised.

Ivan Morris's *The Nobility of Failure* (1975), dedicated to Mishima's memory, generalised the romantic irony of defeat into a typology of Japanese heroism, from Yamato Takeru and Minamoto no Yoshitsune through Kusunoki Masashige and Ōshio Heihachirō to Saigō Takamori and the Special Attack pilots: heroes whose sincerity is certified by their failure, and whose failure is the form in which sincerity becomes visible. Morris's typology is indispensable, but it describes a sensibility rather than an ontology. What the Japan Romantic School contributed to Mishima was not merely the love of the doomed but a metaphysical intuition that the school itself never fully articulated: that value resides not in objects but in the pattern of their loss, and that a tradition is transmitted not by preserving its bearers but by sacrificing them.

2.5
The Depth of the Surface

The genealogy may now be summarised as a second premise. From Nietzsche, Mishima took the conviction that form is on the surface and that superficiality, rightly understood, is the achievement of profundity. From Mann, he took the conviction that beauty is spirit made visible and

that visibility is fatal to the one who pursues it. From the decadence, he took the emblem of the ornament that kills its bearer. From the Japan Romantic School, he took the conviction that value lies in the pattern of loss and that transmission requires sacrifice. Combined, these yield the proposition that the surface is sustained only by being renewed, and that renewal requires the destruction of the bearer. The movement from the Greek journey of 1952 to *Bunka bōeiron* in 1968 is therefore not a movement from classicism to romanticism, as the conventional periodisation holds, but from one classicism to another: from a classicism of the permanent object, embodied in the marble that outlives its makers, to a classicism of the periodic replica, embodied in the cypress that must be felled every twenty years so that the form may remain new. The first classicism could be achieved by the body in the gymnasium. The second, as the following chapters will argue, could be achieved by the body only in its destruction.

CHAPTER THREE

The Sword and the Void

Hagakure, Yōmeigaku, Zen, and Shintō Nativism

3.1 *Hagakure* as a Posthistorical Text

The most frequently cited sentence of the Japanese martial tradition was spoken by a warrior who never fought. Yamamoto Tsunetomo (1659–1719), a retainer of Nabeshima Mitsushige, lord of Saga, wished on his master's death in 1700 to follow him by *junshi*, the retainer's suicide of fidelity; the practice had been prohibited since the 1660s, and Tsunetomo instead took the tonsure and withdrew to a hermitage, where between about 1710 and 1716 a younger samurai, Tashiro Tsuramoto, recorded his discourses. The resulting collection, *Hagakure* (*Hidden by Leaves*), circulated in manuscript within the domain, was rediscovered as martial scripture in the 1930s, and was consigned after 1945 to the lumber-room of discredited ideology, from which Mishima retrieved it in *Hagakure nyūmon* (1967; *The Way of the Samurai*, trans. Kathryn Sparling, 1977), presenting it as the only book he had carried unbroken from the war into the postwar decades.

The central proposition—*bushidō to iu wa shinu koto to mitsuketari*, the Way of the warrior is found in dying—is ordinarily read as a martial imperative. Its situation of utterance tells a different story. *Hagakure* was composed a century into the Tokugawa peace, by a man for whom battle was a legend and the death of fidelity a forbidden rite. It is a doctrine of death formulated precisely where death had ceased to be available as a meaningful act: a *posthistorical* text, in the sense this thesis will give the

term, written after the end of the history that would have given its imperatives content. This is why Mishima could recognise himself in it. The survivor of 1945, who had missed the death his generation had been educated to expect, found in Tsunetomo a predecessor who had also outlived his occasion and had converted the unavailable death into a discipline of daily rehearsal.

Three features of Tsunetomo's teaching, as Mishima received it, bear directly on the argument. The first is the logic of decision: when life and death are equally possible, one should choose death; a death that fails of its object may be a dog's death, but it is not shameful, whereas a life preserved for the sake of an object is contaminated by calculation. Death thus functions not as a goal but as the condition of an action freed from utility, and Mishima's commentary accordingly reads *Hagakure* as a philosophy of freedom. The second is the cosmetics of death. Tsunetomo advises the samurai to carry rouge powder in his sleeve, so that if his complexion is poor on waking or after drinking he may colour his cheeks and not appear pale before an enemy: the warrior's death must be *seen*, and its visibility must be prepared. No passage in the premodern tradition states the thanatoplastic principle more exactly. The third is *shinobu koi*, the secret love that is never declared and is carried to the grave, a love perfected by its refusal of expression. Mishima reads it as the highest form of eros; Chapter 7 will argue that it is also the structure of the loyalist's love for an Emperor who does not return it.

3.2
Yōmeigaku: Knowing as Doing

If *Hagakure* supplied the ethic, the Neo-Confucianism of Wang Yangming (1472–1529), known in Japan as Yōmeigaku, supplied the epistemology. Against the Zhu Xi orthodoxy, which located principle in things and made knowledge a matter of patient investigation, Wang held that the mind is principle, that every person possesses an innate knowing of the good (*liangzhi*, *ryōchi*), and that knowing and acting form a single reality (*zhixing heyi*, *chikō gōitsu*), so that knowledge not enacted is not yet knowledge. The Japanese lineage runs from Nakae Tōju (1608–1648) and Kumazawa Banzan (1619–1691) to its insurrectionary culmination in Ōshio Heihachirō (1793–1837), the former police official and Yōmei teacher who in 1837 led a rising in Osaka on behalf of the famine-stricken poor, was defeated within a day, and some forty days later, when the authorities discovered his hiding place, took his own life together with his adopted

son, setting fire to the house in which they had hidden. Ōshio's doctrine of *kitaikyo*, the return of the mind to the Great Void (*taikyo*), adapted from Zhang Zai's cosmology, held that the mind purified of selfish desire rejoins the undifferentiated source in which life and death are one; from that standpoint the sacrifice of the body is no loss.

In "Kakumei tetsugaku to shite no Yōmeigaku" ("Yōmeigaku as a Revolutionary Philosophy", 1970), published two months before his death, Mishima traced the lineage from Ōshio through Yoshida Shōin (1830–1859) to Saigō Takamori and presented Yōmeigaku as the latent revolutionary philosophy of Japanese action, grounded not in a programme but in the void. The essay is the theoretical warrant for *bunbu ryōdō*, the conjoint way of letters and the sword; but it also, and more deeply, undermines the literary half of that conjunction. If knowing is acting, then the writer who knows but does not act does not truly know, and the entire literary life becomes a knowledge that has not yet become itself. *Honba* (*Runaway Horses*, 1969) will stage the contest between the Yōmei hero, Iinuma Isao, who acts on innate knowing, and the witness Honda, a magistrate whose knowing is precisely a refusal to act. The tetralogy's final verdict, as Chapter 9 will show, belongs to neither.

3.3

Zen: Killing the Buddha

The Rinzai tradition bequeathed a rhetoric of liberating violence. The recorded sayings of Linji (d. 866) enjoin the practitioner to kill the Buddha if he meets him, and the patriarchs and his own parents likewise, as the condition of freedom from every attachment. The fourteenth case of the *Mumonkan* (*Wumenguan*, 1228), which will govern the central crisis of *Kinkakuji*, recounts how Nansen, finding the monks of the eastern and western halls disputing possession of a cat, seized the animal and demanded a word that would save it; when none came, he cut it in two. That evening his disciple Jōshū, told of the event, placed his sandals on his head and walked out, and Nansen remarked that had Jōshū been present the cat would have lived. The kōan presents two responses to attachment: the decisive act that severs, and the inverted gesture that exposes the absurdity of the dispute without destroying its object.

The Tokugawa synthesis of Zen and swordsmanship generalised the first response into a psychology of action. Takuan Sōhō's *Fudōchi shinmyōroku*, addressed to the sword master Yagyū Munenori, describes a mind that does not abide anywhere and therefore responds everywhere;

Munenori's *Heihō kadensho* (1632) distinguishes the sword that kills from the sword that gives life, and identifies them at the highest level. D. T. Suzuki's *Zen and Japanese Culture* (1959; first published 1938) presented this synthesis to the West as the spiritual essence of the samurai, and Brian Victoria's *Zen at War* (1997) documented how the same doctrines of no-mind and the life-giving sword had been mobilised to relieve the soldiers of the imperial army of the burden of guilt. The void of Zen, on this reading, is a void that *authorises*: it removes the self that might hesitate and leaves only the act.

3.4

The Philosophers of Nothingness and the Overcoming of Modernity

The Kyoto School translated this void into a philosophy of history. Nishida Kitarō's logic of place and absolute nothingness, and Nishitani Keiji's later distinction between the nihility of European nihilism and the field of emptiness (*Shūkyō to wa nani ka*, 1961), offered a Buddhist resource for overcoming the crisis Nietzsche had diagnosed. In wartime these resources were drawn into public argument. The symposium on "Overcoming Modernity" (*Kindai no chōkoku*), held in July 1942 and published in *Bungakukai*, gathered Nishitani, Suzuki Shigetaka, Shimomura Toratarō, Kobayashi Hideo, Kamei Katsuichirō, Hayashi Fusao, and others; the roundtables on "The World-Historical Standpoint and Japan" in *Chūō kōron* (1941–1942), with Kōsaka Masaaki, Kōyama Iwao, Nishitani, and Suzuki, spoke of the "moral energy" of the nation and of the war as the world-historical self-negation of the modern. Richard Calichman's edition of the symposium (2008) and Harry Harootunian's *Overcome by Modernity* (2000) have reconstructed the stakes. What matters here is the structure the Kyoto School made available to Mishima's generation: the conviction that an act grounded in nothingness could break through the closure of a completed modernity and restart history. Mishima's action after 1945 re-performs this logic under conditions the Kyoto School had not foreseen, in a history that had already been declared finished.

3.5

Nativism: Masculine Style, Sincere Heart, and the League of the Divine Wind

The fourth tradition is the most intimate. The *kokugaku* of the eighteenth century sought beneath the sedimented Chinese learning a native sensibility. Kamo no Mabuchi (1697–1769) opposed the manly vigour of the *Man'yōshū* (*masuraoburi*) to the delicate femininity of the Heian court poetry (*taoyameburi*). Motoori Norinaga (1730–1801) defined the native heart through *mono no aware*, the pathos of things, and the sincere heart (*magokoro*) against the rationalising Chinese heart (*karagokoro*). Hirata Atsutane (1776–1843) turned the philology into a religion of the unseen world and its spirits, and his disciples carried it into the loyalist movements of the Restoration.

The purest issue of this tradition, and the one Mishima studied most closely, was the rising of the Shinpūren, the League of the Divine Wind, at Kumamoto in October 1876. Its members, disciples of the Shintō teacher Hayashi Ōen, sought the gods' sanction through the divination of *ukei*, refused firearms as polluting, and attacked the modern garrison by night with swords and spears. They killed the garrison commander, Taneda Masaaki, mortally wounded the prefectural governor, Yasuoka Ryōsuke, and killed or wounded officers and soldiers, many of them surprised in their quarters; within a day the garrison's rifles had destroyed them, and many of the survivors took their own lives. Legend held that they would pass beneath telegraph wires holding white fans over their heads. The Shinpūren is the historical paradigm of an action whose form negates its political efficacy, lethal to its victims and futile as politics: the refusal of modern means was the content of its sincerity, and the certainty of defeat was the guarantee of its purity. In Kojève's vocabulary, which Chapter 11 will develop, it is the moment at which snobbery—the pure adherence to form without regard to outcome—becomes tragedy by costing lives, its victims' as well as its own. *Runaway Horses* places a history of the Shinpūren at its centre, as the book Isao lends to Honda; Mishima's own research for it took him to Kumamoto in 1966.

The nativist tradition also supplied the political form of reincarnation. At the battle of Minatogawa in 1336, according to the *Taiheiki*, Kusunoki Masashige, defending the cause of Emperor Go-Daigo in a battle he had advised against and knew to be lost, exchanged with his brother Masasue the vow to be reborn seven times as the same man to destroy the enemies of the court, and the two then died by each other's swords. The phrase in

which the vow was later condensed, *shichishō hōkoku*, "repaying the nation through seven lives", was inscribed on the headbands worn at Ichigaya. Kusunoki's vow is the loyalist version of the sengū hypothesis: the same form of fidelity, renewed through the destruction and replacement of its bodily bearers. *The Sea of Fertility* fuses it with Buddhist rebirth, and in doing so submits it to a Buddhist critique.

3.6

Two Voids

The Japanese traditions thus offered Mishima two voids, and the distinction between them organises the rest of this thesis. The first is the void that authorises: the daily rehearsal of death in *Hagakure*, the Great Void of Ōshio's *kitaikyo*, the no-mind of the Zen swordsman, the absolute nothingness that the wartime Kyoto School enlisted for a war of world-historical renewal. In this void the self disappears and the act remains, pure because groundless. The second is the void that annuls: the Yogācāra analysis, studied by Honda in *The Temple of Dawn*, according to which the world and the self alike are representations arising from a storehouse consciousness that is itself renewed and destroyed from moment to moment. In this void it is not the self that disappears but the act, together with the world in which it would have taken effect. The first void produced the Ichigaya act. The second produced the final page of the tetralogy. That the second was written before the first was performed is the fact on which the thesis turns.

CHAPTER FOUR

Eros, Transgression, Expenditure

Bataille, Sade, and the Liebestod



4.1 Bataille: Continuity, Transgression, Sovereignty

Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) supplied the theory of which Mishima's erotic fiction had been, for a decade, an unwitting demonstration. Human beings, Bataille argues, are discontinuous: each is born and dies alone, separated from every other by an abyss. Eroticism, like death, opens discontinuous beings onto a continuity they cannot survive, and Bataille accordingly defines it as the affirmation of life up to and into death. The interdict and its transgression are not opposites. Transgression does not abolish the taboo but completes it, lifting it without suppressing it, so that the sacred is experienced precisely in the violation that the prohibition makes possible. *La Part maudite* (1949) had extended the analysis into a general economy: the surplus energy that the sun lavishes on the earth must be expended, and societies distinguish themselves by the forms of their useless expenditure—sacrifice, festival, luxury, war. Sovereignty, the culminating concept of Bataille's thought, names the moment that serves no end, the instant withdrawn from the world of projects; and Bataille insisted, with a characteristic typographical emphasis, that sovereignty so understood is nothing.

Mishima read Bataille in the 1960s and praised him as a Nietzsche of eroticism, and the praise is precise: Bataille gave to the erotic what Nietzsche had given to the aesthetic, a status beyond utility and morality. The Japanese reception of Bataille and Sade was mediated above all by

Shibusawa Tatsuhiko, whose translation of Sade's *Histoire de Juliette* provoked a prosecution for obscenity that ran from 1961 to 1969 and became a cause célèbre of postwar literary freedom. The four works examined in this chapter—*Yūkoku*, *Haru no yuki*, *Sado kōshaku fujin*, and *Waga tomo Hittorā*—may be read as successive experiments in Bataillean economy, and the last of them as the moment at which Mishima's own fiction discovers the limit of the economy it celebrates.

4.2

Yūkoku: The Liebestod as Form

"Yūkoku" ("Patriotism", 1961) is set in the days of the 2.26 Incident of February 1936. Lieutenant Takeyama Shinji, recently married, has been excluded by his comrades from the rising out of consideration for his bride; ordered to lead troops against them, he can neither betray his friends nor disobey his sovereign, and he resolves on seppuku. His wife Reiko, who has vowed to follow him, is its witness; the couple make love a final time before the household shrine, and the story narrates his death, and then hers, with a clinical deliberation that is the formal centre of the work: he cuts open his abdomen with his sword and ends his life by driving the blade into his throat, and she, having watched, takes her own life with a dagger to her throat. The story's politics are pointedly empty. Takeyama dies neither for the rebels nor for the government; he dies to escape an impossible choice, and the death therefore has no content except its form. It is loyalty without an object, eros without a future, and it is presented, in a strict Bataillean sense, as sovereign: an expenditure that serves nothing.

The film that Mishima wrote, directed, produced, and performed in 1965, released in 1966, stripped the story further. Shot on a bare Nō-like set, silent, its text reduced to scrolled intertitles, it is accompanied throughout by the *Liebestod* from Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde*. After Mishima's death his widow had the prints withdrawn, and the film was presumed lost until its negative was recovered at the family house in 2005. The choice of music is a philosophical citation. *Tristan* (1865) is the opera in which Wagner, under the impress of his reading of Schopenhauer, staged the union of love and death as the dissolution of individuation in the night; yet it has long been observed that Wagner's lovers do not deny the will but will their extinction with an ecstatic intensity that is the will's most emphatic affirmation. The *Liebestod* is thus the musical form of the confusion that Schopenhauer's §69 diagnoses in sui-

cide, and *Yūkoku* inherits it: an apparent negation that is in truth an affirmation of desire so extreme that only death can contain it.

Denis de Rougemont's *L'Amour et l'Occident* (1939) had traced the Tristan myth to a Western passion that loves the obstacle more than the beloved and whose true object is death. *Haru no yuki* (*Spring Snow*, 1969) is the most rigorous Japanese transposition of Rougemont's thesis. Matsugae Kiyoaki is indifferent to Ayakura Satoko until her betrothal to an imperial prince receives the Emperor's sanction; at that moment she becomes forbidden, and in becoming forbidden she becomes the object of an overwhelming passion. The obstacle is not a rival or a family feud but the imperial will itself. In violating it, Kiyoaki experiences his transgression as grandeur, and the sacred is felt, in exact accordance with Bataille, only in the moment of its profanation. The Emperor, who will occupy the centre of Chapter 7, enters the tetralogy not as an object of worship but as the source of the interdict whose transgression makes eros absolute.

4.3

Madame de Sade and My *Friend Hitler*: The Absent Centre and the Liquidation of the Pure

Sado kōshaku fujin (*Madame de Sade*, 1965) originated, Mishima explained, in a puzzle he found in Shibusawa's biography of Sade: why Renée de Montreuil, who had defended her husband with unwavering fidelity through years of scandal and imprisonment, refused to see him when he was at last released in 1790. The play's answer is its form. Six women, among them Renée, her mother Madame de Montreuil, and personifications of piety and libertinage, debate Sade across eighteen years; Sade himself never appears. He is present only as a discourse—as the object of the women's rhetoric and as the author of the texts he writes in prison—and the play ends when Renée, having read *Justine*, understands that he has enclosed her within a world of words in which she figures as a character. When the aged Sade arrives at the door, shabby and corpulent, she sends word that she will never see him again. The man is rejected as an inferior copy of the image that his writing and her devotion had constructed. The play thus dramatises, fifteen years before the fact, the precise difficulty of iconic anteriority: the actual body, when it finally arrives, cannot equal the image that preceded it.

Waga tomo Hittorā (*My Friend Hitler*, 1968), conceived as the male counterpart to *Madame de Sade*, reverses the configuration. Its four

characters—Hitler, Ernst Röhm, Gregor Strasser, and the industrialist Gustav Krupp—play out the political logic of the Night of the Long Knives in June 1934. Röhm, the romantic soldier who believes in the friendship of the play's title, is liquidated together with the socialist Strasser so that Hitler can consolidate power at the centre with the support of capital and the army; the play ends with Hitler's declaration that politics must take the middle road. It is Mishima's most lucid political text, and its lucidity is turned against its author. The pure warrior is destroyed by the sovereign he idealises, exactly as the 2.26 officers were condemned by the Emperor they invoked; the romantic of action is an instrument whom power discards once used. Written in the year of the Tatenokai's founding, *My Friend Hitler* already contains the refutation of the fantasy it accompanies, and it is the first clear instance of the pattern this thesis claims for the whole corpus: the fiction knows what the act will refuse to know.

4.4
The Japanese Genealogy of the Erotic Image: Tanizaki, Kawabata, Ranpo

The Japanese tradition of the erotic image that Mishima inherited had already converted bodies into surfaces for inscription. Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's "Shisei" ("The Tattooer", 1910) tells of an artist who inscribes an immense spider on the back of a young girl and thereby transforms her into the cruel beauty the image demands: the design precedes and produces the person. Kawabata Yasunari's *Nemureru bijo* (*House of the Sleeping Beauties*, 1961), which Mishima admired, reduces eros to the contemplation of drugged girls who cannot return the gaze, an erotics of the body as image in which reciprocity has been abolished. Edogawa Ranpo's *Kurotokage* (*Black Lizard*, 1934), which Mishima adapted for the stage in 1961, features a master criminal who preserves beautiful human beings as dolls in an underground museum. In Fukasaku Kinji's film of the play (1968), starring Maruyama (later Miwa) Akihiro, whose performance of femininity Susan Sontag's "Notes on 'Camp'" (1964) might have been written to describe, Mishima appears briefly as one of the exhibits: a young man's body preserved as a living statue. It is difficult to imagine a more literal emblem of thanatoplasty than the author posed, for the camera, as a specimen in a museum of embalmed beauty.

4.5

The Economy of Thanatoplasty and Its Limits

The erotic works thus compose an economy in which the beloved, or the self, is completed as an image by death. *Yūkoku* makes death the consummation of both love and loyalty; *Spring Snow* locates the sacred in the transgression of the imperial interdict; *Madame de Sade* shows the actual body rejected as an inferior copy of its image; *My Friend Hitler* shows the pure liquidated by the power it serves. Feminist criticism has rightly observed that this economy is conducted largely at the expense of women, who figure as witnesses, mirrors, and followers—Reiko dies after her husband, Satoko renounces the world, Renée retires to a convent—and queer criticism has shown that the heterosexual couple of *Yūkoku* serves as a mask for the contemplation of the wounded male body, which remains, from the Sebastian of *Kamen no kokuhaku* onward, the true object of the gaze. Both critiques are correct, and both can be deepened by returning to Bataille.

Sovereignty, for Bataille, is incompatible with project. The instant that serves no end cannot be made to serve an end without falling back into the servile world of means. The act of 1970 attempted to be at once sovereign and instrumental: a useless expenditure of life, performed in the form of *Yūkoku*, and simultaneously a demand, addressed to the Self-Defense Forces in a written manifesto, for constitutional revision. By Bataille's own logic the combination is impossible. The manifesto converts sovereignty into project; the project, having failed, reconverts the death into an expenditure whose uselessness is now involuntary. Mishima's erotic theory, in other words, already contained the critique of his political practice. The fiction of the useless death was sovereign because it was fiction. The act that sought to make that fiction bleed could not remain sovereign without renouncing its message, and could not deliver its message without ceasing to be sovereign.

PART II

Structures

The hypothesis tried in a burned temple, a regimen of the body, and a theology of the empty centre.

05 Beauty as Barrier

06 *Sun and Steel*

07 The Emperor as Empty Centre

CHAPTER FIVE

Beauty as Barrier

The Temple of the Golden Pavilion

5.1 The Fire and the Replica

In the early hours of 2 July 1950 a twenty-one-year-old acolyte of Rokuonji, Hayashi Yōken, set fire to the Golden Pavilion, the three-storeyed reliquary hall that Ashikaga Yoshimitsu had raised at the end of the fourteenth century, and fled to the hill behind the temple, where he was found after attempting to take his own life with sleeping tablets and a knife. He survived, was sentenced to seven years' imprisonment, and died of tuberculosis in 1956. The building, a National Treasure, burned to the ground. The fire occurred two months after the enactment of the Law for the Protection of Cultural Properties, itself prompted by the fire that had destroyed the wall paintings of the Hōryūji Kondō in 1949, and it confronted the new heritage regime with the question that regime was designed to exclude: what survives when the original material of a work is lost? The answer given by the state was practical and, in its own terms, severe. The pavilion was rebuilt from surviving plans and photographs and completed in 1955; the reconstruction was not re-designated a National Treasure, since authenticity, in the modern conservationist understanding that the law embodied, inheres in original material.

Mishima's *Kinkakuji* was serialised in 1956 and published as a book in the same year. It was written, that is, in the presence of the replica. This circumstance, rarely remarked, makes the novel the first trial of the

sengū hypothesis in Mishima's corpus. The pavilion whose destruction the novel narrates already stood again, gilded and new, when the novel appeared, and every reader who has since visited Kyoto has seen the copy through the lens of the novel's original. The novel is thus itself a second reconstruction, a rebuilding in words of the building whose burning it recounts, and the fame it acquired has conferred on the replica an aura that the heritage law denied it. Iconic anteriority operates here at the scale of a culture: millions now see the Golden Pavilion only after, and through, its representation.

5.2

The Stutter and the Priority of the Described

The narrator, Mizoguchi, a priest's son from the remote Japan Sea coast, is a stutterer, and the stutter is the novel's founding figure of non-coincidence. The stutterer's word arrives late, after the world has moved on; between intention and utterance falls a delay in which the self is always excluded from the present of the others. Mizoguchi's relation to beauty is structured by a second delay of the same kind. His father has described the Golden Pavilion to him as the most beautiful thing on earth, and the description precedes the sight by years. When he finally stands before the building, he sees only a small, dark, old structure, and feels nothing; the pavilion becomes beautiful again only when he has left it and it is restored to the domain of image, reflected in the pond and multiplied in memory. The Golden Pavilion is thus the Sebastian of Mizoguchi's life: an image that precedes the object, and against which the object can only disappoint.

The war briefly abolishes the delay. In the months of the air raids Mizoguchi comes to believe that the pavilion will burn as he will burn, and that a common destruction will unite him with beauty; the prospect of shared annihilation makes the building intimate. The surrender of 15 August 1945 dissolves the intimacy. The pavilion has survived; it has returned to its eternity, and Mizoguchi, who had hoped to perish with it, is expelled into a postwar in which beauty stands aloof and the bond of common destruction is broken. The novel's most profound historical insight is here. For Mizoguchi, as for Mishima, the end of the war is not a liberation but the restoration of a separation, the beginning of a posthistory in which the beautiful form endures and the subject who might have died with it survives without purpose. That evening the Superior of the temple lectures the assembled monks on Nansen's cat.

5.3

Beauty Interposing: Lacan's Barrier and Heidegger's Temple

Whenever Mizoguchi approaches a woman—a girl on an outing to Arashiyama, a woman procured for him by his friend Kashiwagi, a woman he had once glimpsed from the gate of Nanzenji and who, years later, bares her breast before him—the pavilion appears between them and renders him impotent. Beauty interposes itself as a barrier between desire and its object. Jacques Lacan's seminar on *The Ethics of Psychoanalysis* (1959–1960) offers the most exact commentary. Lacan argues that beauty functions as the last barrier before the Thing, the traumatic core of desire: the splendour of Antigone, standing between two deaths, arrests the spectator at the threshold of the horror she approaches, and the beautiful has the effect of suspending and disarming desire at the very point where it would otherwise pass into destruction. Mizoguchi's pavilion is such a barrier, but it operates in reverse. It does not protect him from the Thing; it protects the Thing—an undifferentiated world of bodies and appetites—from him, and it condemns him to a desire that can find no object because every object is measured against a form it cannot equal.

Martin Heidegger's "Der Ursprung des Kunstwerkes" (1935–1936, published 1950) describes the Greek temple as the work that sets up a world and sets forth the earth, the building that first gives to things their look and to human beings their outlook on themselves. The Golden Pavilion is a Heideggerian temple experienced from outside the world it opens. It institutes an order of beauty in which Mizoguchi has no place; it gives to things their look and to him only the certainty of his exclusion. The novel's solution follows from the diagnosis. If the work opens a world from which the subject is barred, the subject can enter the world only by destroying the work.

5.4

Kashiwagi, Tsurukawa, and the Kōan of the Cat

Two friends define the poles between which Mizoguchi moves. Tsurukawa, bright and guileless, translates Mizoguchi's dark thoughts into innocent readings, and his death, presented at first as an accident, is later revealed by his letters to have been a suicide arising from an unhappy love, so that even transparency proves to have concealed its own interior. Kashiwagi, club-footed and cynical, has made of his deformity an

instrument of seduction and a philosophy. He reads the kōan of Nansen's cat as a contest between action and cognition: the act that kills beauty, and the cognition that leaves beauty intact but transforms the world into something that can be endured. Beauty, for Kashiwagi, is a tormenting presence, like an aching tooth that insists on itself and becomes, once extracted, a small bloody object of no significance; cognition, he claims, is the only thing that can change the world, since action changes nothing essential.

Mizoguchi chooses action. On the night of 1 July 1950, having resolved to burn the pavilion and to die in its topmost chamber, the Kukyōchō, the Summit of the Ultimate, he sets the fire and climbs to the third storey. The door is locked. He beats against it and is refused. The ultimate will not admit him, and he flees through the smoke to the hill behind the temple, where, watching the sparks rise over the trees, he discovers the knife and the bottle of Calmotin sleeping tablets he had brought for his own death, throws them away, lights a cigarette, and resolves to live, like a man who has finished a day's work. Here Mishima inverts his source: the historical arsonist had turned the knife and the tablets on himself. The ending is decisive for the argument of this thesis. Mishima's first great novel of destruction concludes not with the death of the subject but with the death of the image and the survival of the body. The act destroys beauty so that the destroyer may live; and it is precisely this structure that the act of 1970 will invert, destroying the body so that it may become an image.

5.5
Herostratus, Hell Screen, and the Theory Tested

The comparative frame clarifies what is singular in Mizoguchi's act. Herostratus, who in 356 BCE burned the temple of Artemis at Ephesus to make his name immortal, was punished with a decree forbidding the mention of his name, and survives in memory precisely by virtue of the prohibition; his act is a transaction in fame. Jean-Paul Sartre's "Érostrate" (1939) updates the type as a Parisian misanthrope whose planned massacre collapses into a farce, ending with the would-be killer locked in a lavatory: the act as the failure of the subject to rise to his own image. Akutagawa Ryūnosuke's "Jigokuhen" ("Hell Screen", 1918), which Mishima adapted for the kabuki stage in 1953, supplies the closest analogue and the sharpest contrast. The painter Yoshihide, commissioned to paint the torments of hell, declares that he can paint only what he has seen, and

the lord who commissioned the screen causes a carriage to be burned before his eyes with the painter's daughter inside. Yoshihide completes his masterpiece and then hangs himself. Akutagawa's fable states in its purest form the demand at the heart of thanatoplasty: that the representation be underwritten by a real suffering, that the copy be earned by a burning original.

Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment* (1866) completes the frame. Raskolnikov's murder is the test of a theory, the proposition that the extraordinary man may overstep the moral law; its refutation is his inability to bear what he has done, and its resolution is confession and exile. Mizoguchi's arson is likewise the test of a theory, the proposition that the destruction of beauty will free him to live. The novel confirms the theory in the most disquieting way possible: he does wish to live, and the cigarette is the sign of a freedom purchased by the destruction of the form that had held him in bondage. Yet the historical frame of the novel refutes the theory at a level the narrator cannot reach. The pavilion was rebuilt. The form survived the destruction of its bearer, and the act that was meant to abolish beauty merely occasioned its replication.

This is why *Kinkakuji* stands at the origin of the sengū hypothesis and, simultaneously, of its critique. The novel shows that the destruction of an image does not destroy its form, which returns in a copy; it thereby anticipates the thesis of *Bunka bōeiron*. But it also shows, by the same token, that an act of destruction cannot be the last word, since the culture that preserves forms through replication will replicate whatever the act destroyed—and will, in time, replicate the act itself as an image. The arsonist survives into the novel, the novel into the replica, the replica into the tourist's photograph. The logic that will receive 25 November 1970 as its own reproduction is already fully operative in 1956.

CHAPTER SIX

Sun and Steel

The Somatic Turn and Thanatoplasty

6.1

Confidential Criticism

Taiyō to tetsu (*Sun and Steel*), serialised in the journal *Hihyō* from 1965 to 1968 and translated by John Bester in 1970, is Mishima's philosophical testament, and it opens by refusing the two genres to which it might belong. It is neither confession, which presupposes an interior to be disclosed, nor criticism, which presupposes an object held at a distance; Mishima proposes instead a hybrid he calls confidential criticism, a form in which the self is examined as if it were a text by another and the text is examined as if it were a body. The book's first movement restates, now as theory, the iconic anteriority of *Kamen no kokuhaku*. Words, Mishima writes, came before flesh. The child raised in his grandmother Natsu's darkened sickroom, kept from the sun and from other boys, knew the body first through language, and language, like termites working within timber, had hollowed out his experience before he possessed it. When the body arrived, it arrived late and already clothed in words, as a concept seeking its own realisation.

The somatic turn that the book records is therefore not a flight from language into the body but an attempt to reverse the order of their arrival: to acquire, by discipline, a body that would precede its words, and thus to become, retrospectively, an original rather than a copy. The attempt has two instruments, named in the title. The sun, discovered on the deck of the ship that carried him to the Americas and Greece in 1952, is

the principle of visibility, the light in which forms are displayed on surfaces without depth. Steel, the iron of the barbell taken up in 1955, is the principle of formation, the resistance against which muscle is produced by repetition. Muscle, in Mishima's analysis, is the most unspiritual of forms: produced by labour, useless in modern life, it exists only to be seen and to exist. It is, in Bataille's terms, a sovereign expenditure of energy, and in the terms of this thesis, the first material of thanatoplasty.

6.2
The Portable Shrine and the Blue Sky

The book's most luminous passage concerns a festival. Mishima had long wondered what the young men carrying a *mikoshi*, a portable shrine, through the streets saw in their frenzy, and he had assumed it to be something inaccessible to the solitary consciousness of the writer. When he joined them, in the mid-1950s, he found that what they saw was nothing but the sky—an intense, absurd, blank blue—and the discovery was for him a revelation of communion. The body, submitted to a collective rhythm, could see what others saw; the sealed consciousness of the sickroom could at last share an experience that was not mediated by words.

The image is richer than Mishima's reading of it. A *mikoshi* is a vessel for the temporary presence of a god, borne on the shoulders of bodies that sway beneath it; at its centre is not a visible deity but an enclosed emptiness, animated only by the collective labour of those who carry it. The festival is a structure in which a sacred void is made present by bodies. It is the Emperor-system in miniature, as Chapter 7 will argue, and it is the sengū in miniature as well, since the god is renewed in the festival precisely by being carried, shaken, and returned. What the bearers see is the sky: the blankness above the void they bear. Mishima understood the vision as communion. It can equally be understood as a figure of the vacancy at the centre of every structure of sacred transmission—a vacancy that the tetralogy's final garden will expose without the consolation of the crowd.

6.3
Pain as Proof

Sun and Steel assigns to pain a precise epistemological function. In the discipline of boxing and kendo, and in the ordeal of physical exhaustion, pain is the one sensation that guarantees the coincidence of conscious-

ness with the body; it is the proof that the body is not merely an image. Ernst Jünger's *Über den Schmerz* (1934) had made pain the measure by which an age reveals its values, and had identified, in the soldier and the worker of the technological era, a new capacity to regard one's own body as an object. Jünger's instrument for this objectification was the photograph, which he read as the medium of a second, colder consciousness that stands outside the zone of sensitivity and records the body's suffering as if it belonged to another. *In Stahlgewittern* (1920), his memoir of the Western Front, had already rendered the wounded body with that cold exactitude. Mishima's thanatoplasty unites Jünger's two terms: pain as the proof of reality, and the photograph as the second consciousness that fixes the proven body as an image.

Franz Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) is the parable of this union and of its failure. The apparatus of the penal colony inscribes the sentence on the condemned man's body with needles, and the officer who tends it believes that in the sixth hour the condemned man deciphers the sentence with his wounds and is transfigured by understanding. When the officer, his machine discredited, places himself beneath the harrow, the apparatus malfunctions; it kills him without inscription, and the traveller sees in the dead face no trace of the promised transfiguration. Kafka's machine is the most exact figure in modern literature for the copy that bleeds: the sentence was to become one with the body, the text with the flesh, and the moment of coincidence was to be a revelation. What the story records instead is a death without writing and a face without meaning. The officer's failed transfiguration anticipates the reception of the event of 1970 more precisely than any work Mishima himself could have known.

J. G. Ballard's *Crash* (1973), written in the years immediately following, supplies a technological counterpart. Its prophet, Vaughan, rehearses in photographs and staged collisions the death he intends to die in a crash with a film star, and the wounds of the automobile become the signs of a new sexuality. The Futurism of F. T. Marinetti, whose founding manifesto of 1909 glorified war as the world's only hygiene (*guerra sola igiene del mondo*), stands at the origin of this lineage, in which the machine is the instrument by which the body is converted into spectacle. Mishima's machine was the F-104.

6.4

The F-104 and the Ouroboros

In December 1967 Mishima flew as a passenger in an F-104 Starfighter from Hyakuri Air Base, and the epilogue of *Sun and Steel* recounts the flight. At altitude, beyond the pressure of ordinary life, he experienced a state in which consciousness and body seemed at last to coincide, and he saw below him a vast white serpent of cloud encircling the earth and biting its own tail: an ouroboros in which every polarity of his existence—word and flesh, spirit and matter, life and death—appeared reconciled. The book closes with a poem, "Icarus", that asks whether the desire to ascend toward the sun is itself the cause of the fall.

The flight is a rehearsal and a replica. It reproduces, by the courtesy of the Self-Defense Forces and in a machine that would carry him safely home, the final flight that the Special Attack pilots of 1945 had made and that the young Hiraoka had been spared. The ouroboros that crowned it is the classical emblem of eternal return and of self-consuming renewal—the sengū, as it were, of the cosmos—and Mishima's experience of it at the summit of a simulated death is the most complete statement of the thanatoplastic ideal: a unity of consciousness and body, achieved at the threshold of an annihilation that did not occur. The poem's question remained unanswered because the flight was not a fall.

6.5

Bunbu Ryōdō and the Two Deaths

The doctrine of *bunbu ryōdō*, the conjoint way of letters and the sword, receives in *Sun and Steel* a formulation that makes its internal contradiction explicit. Literature, Mishima argues, is the principle of survival: the writer lives on through his words, preserves his experience by translating it into form, and endures as long as the text endures. The sword is the principle of death: action culminates in the instant in which the actor is consumed. To unite the two is not to reconcile them but to live their contradiction until one of them prevails. In the terms of this thesis the contradiction is exactly that of the sengū. Letters are the renewal of the form in a copy; the sword is the destruction of the bearer. The double ending of 25 November—manuscript in the morning, death at noon—is *bunbu ryōdō* completed on a single day, and it therefore also marks the moment at which the two principles, forced into coincidence, pronounce judgement on each other.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Le Visible et l'invisible* (1964) describes the flesh as the chiasm in which seeing and being seen, touching and being touched, reverse into one another, and insists that this reversibility is always imminent and never realised in fact. Mishima's project may be defined as the attempt to realise it in fact: to be at once the seer and the seen, the consciousness and the displayed body, without remainder. The only condition under which the seen could exist without a seer lodged within it is death, when the body becomes pure image and the consciousness that would have regarded it has ceased. Thanatoplasty is the pursuit of the chiasm's closure, and the closure it attains is a corpse.

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) furnishes the fable of the self-made body. The creature, assembled from the dead, learns to speak by overhearing a family and to think by reading *Paradise Lost*, Plutarch's *Lives*, and *The Sorrows of Werter*: its words, too, came before its flesh had a place in the world. Rejected by its maker, it ends by announcing that it will ascend its funeral pyre on the Arctic ice, and it is borne away into darkness before the reader can know whether the pyre was lit. The creature's suffering makes it more real than the man who made it; its self-destruction is its final claim to originality. The resemblance to Mishima's trajectory is not one of influence but of structure: in both, a body produced according to a prior design seeks to authenticate itself by an act of self-annihilation witnessed by no one who can confirm it.

6.6
Thanatoplasty Defined

The programme can now be stated in full. Thanatoplasty is the sculpting of the living body, under the sun of visibility and against the steel of discipline, into a form destined for death, together with the production, in advance, of the images of that death. Its archive is extensive. In Masumura Yasuzō's *Karakkaze yarō* (*Afraid to Die*, 1960) Mishima played a small-time gangster shot dead at the film's end. Hosoe Eikō's *Barakei* (1963) posed his body in a theatre of roses, hoses, and mirrors. Shinoyama Kishin's Sebastian of 1968 fixed him in the pose of the martyr of his adolescence, and the same photographer's *Otoko no shi*, begun in 1970, staged a series of deaths—by drowning, by accident, by the sword—that were to be published as a book and were withheld for half a century after the one death they did not stage. *Yūkoku* (1966) filmed his seppuku; in Gosha Hideo's *Hitokiri* (1969) he played the swordsman Tanaka Shinbei, who dies by his

own blade. Each of these is a copy of a death that had not yet occurred: iconic anteriority applied to mortality itself.

The consequence is the paradox on which Chapter 11 will build. The event of 1970 was intended to be the original of which all these images were copies, the real that would retroactively authenticate the rehearsals. But the logic of iconic anteriority, which Mishima had formulated with unsurpassed rigour, entails the opposite. Where the image precedes the body, the body's death arrives as the last image of the series; the rehearsals do not become copies of the event, the event becomes the final rehearsal. The monument in which sculptor and stone were to coincide was received, as every monument is, as a representation.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Emperor as Empty Centre

Culture, Kokutai, and the Death of God

7.1

The Humanity Declaration as the Death of God

On 1 January 1946 an imperial rescript denied that the Emperor was a manifest deity (*akitsumikami*) and that the Japanese were a race destined to rule. The document, known as the Humanity Declaration (*Ningen sengen*), accomplished in the idiom of administrative prose what Nietzsche had announced in the idiom of prophecy: the death of God. But it did so with a difference that governs everything Mishima would write about the Emperor. In Nietzsche's parable the god is killed by his worshippers; in the rescript the god abdicates his divinity himself. The murder is a suicide, and the survivors are left not with guilt for a deed they have committed but with the grievance of a love that the beloved has withdrawn.

Mishima gave that grievance its fullest literary form in *Eirei no koe* (*Voices of the Heroic Dead*, 1966). At a séance conducted according to the Shintō technique of *chinkon kishin*, the spirits of the officers executed after the 2.26 Incident, and then of the Special Attack pilots of 1945, speak through the mouth of a blind young medium. They recount their deaths and their fidelity, and their testimony converges on a single refrain, a lament asking why the Emperor chose to become a man. When the séance ends the medium is dead, and his face has become the indistinct face of someone else, a face that readers have been tempted to identify but that the text leaves anonymous. The story is the most exact figure in

the corpus for what this thesis calls the copy that bleeds: the voice of the dead passes through a living body and, in passing, kills it, so that the representation of the dead becomes a real death. The medium is the Ise of the story—the vessel that the form uses up.

Eirei no koe completed what Mishima called his 2.26 trilogy, collected in 1966 with an essay on the incident's meaning for him. "Yūkoku" (1961) had presented the officer who dies in loyalty without an object. The play *Tōka no kiku* (*The Tenth-Day Chrysanthemum*, 1961), whose title alludes to the proverb of the chrysanthemum delivered a day after its festival, presented the statesman who survived the rebels' attack and the woman who saved him: belatedness itself, the survivor as the posthumous. *Eirei no koe* presents the dead accusing the living god. The historical record lends the trilogy its bitterness. On 26 February 1936 the officers whose spirits speak in the story had led some fourteen hundred troops into central Tokyo and assassinated the Lord Keeper of the Privy Seal, Saitō Makoto, the Finance Minister, Takahashi Korekiyo, and the Inspector General of Military Education, Watanabe Jōtarō; they gravely wounded the Grand Chamberlain, Suzuki Kantarō, and killed the Prime Minister's brother-in-law, Matsuo Denzō, whom they mistook for the Prime Minister, Okada Keisuke, together with several of the police officers guarding their targets. The Shōwa Emperor, far from receiving the rebels of 1936 as loyal subjects, condemned them as mutineers and, according to the diary of his aide-de-camp Honjō Shigeru, declared himself ready to lead the Imperial Guard against them. Their love was unrequited in the strictest sense, a *shinobu koi* in the idiom of *Hagakure*, carried to the execution ground. Kita Ikki, the theorist executed in 1937 as their ideological inspirer, had conceived the Emperor as the instrument of a national reconstruction; Mishima's essay on him (1969) acknowledged in Kita the one genuine revolutionary thinker of the Shōwa right and, for that very reason, a thinker whose Emperor was a means rather than an end.

7.2

Bunka bōeiron: Culture as Form and the Emperor as Culture

Bunka bōeiron (*In Defence of Culture*), published in *Chūō kōron* in July 1968, is Mishima's most systematic political essay and the locus classicus of the sengū hypothesis. Its argument proceeds from a definition. Culture is not a collection of objects but a system of forms (*katachi*), including forms of action and of life, and Japanese culture is distinguished by three

characteristics: recurrence (*saikisei*), totality (*zentaisei*), and subjectivity (*shutaisei*). Recurrence is illustrated by the Grand Shrine of Ise. Where the culture of the West preserves its origin in a durable object, as the Parthenon survives as the ruin of an original, Ise is rebuilt every twenty years, and each new shrine is not a copy of the original but the original itself; the distinction between copy and original, Mishima argues, does not exist in this culture, which transmits form through the renewal rather than the conservation of matter. Totality means that culture includes everything from the chrysanthemum to the sword—Mishima's phrase inverts Ruth Benedict's *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword* (1946) into a claim of inclusion—so that the courtly elegance of *miyabi* may, in extremity, assume the form of terror. Subjectivity means that culture is defended not by guarding objects but by becoming it, by living its forms to the point of death.

The Emperor enters as the guarantor of this totality. Against the Meiji constitutional state, which had made the Emperor its political sovereign, and against the organ theory of Minobe Tatsukichi, condemned in 1935, which had made him an organ of that state, Mishima proposes the Emperor as a cultural concept (*bunka gainen to shite no tennō*): not the head of the state but the source and unifying principle of the culture's forms, the point at which all of them, the elegant and the violent alike, are held together. The practical proposals follow—a restoration of the bond between the Emperor and the armed forces through the prerogative of honours, and a repudiation of what Mishima derided as the weekly-magazine Emperor system of the postwar mass media—but the theoretical structure is what matters. The cultural Emperor is Ise raised to the level of sovereignty. The dynasty is a form renewed through the succession of mortal emperors, each of whom is not a copy of the first but the Emperor as such, precisely as each rebuilt shrine is Ise as such.

The essay provoked a critique from Hashikawa Bunzō, "Bi no ronri to seiji no ronri" ("The Logic of Beauty and the Logic of Politics", 1968), to which Mishima replied with an open letter. Hashikawa's objection went to the heart of the matter. An Emperor who guarantees a totality of culture that includes rebellion cannot be reconciled with any actual state; and the history of the 1930s showed that when the cultural Emperor was fused with the state, the result was not the liberation of culture but its subordination to power. The critique anticipates *My Friend Hitler*, which Mishima wrote in the same year, and it anticipates the reception of 1970, in which the appeal to the cultural Emperor was received by the state as disorder.

7.3

The King's Two Bodies and the Vacant Plot

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval political theology in which the king possesses a mortal body natural and an undying body politic, so that the dignity never dies though its bearers do. Japanese political theology possesses a homologous doctrine, articulated most influentially by Orikuchi Shinobu in "Daijōsai no hongi" (1928): the imperial spirit (*tennōrei*) passes from emperor to emperor through the accession rite of the Daijōsai, in which the new sovereign, secluded within the ritual bedding of the sacred hall, receives the spirit that makes him Emperor. The individual body is a vessel through which the form passes. Mishima's attitude to Orikuchi was ambivalent; "Mikumano mōde" ("Pilgrimage to the Three Mountains of Kumano", 1965), a story widely read as a satirical portrait of a scholar-poet modelled on him, suggests a distance from the man. But the structure of the tennōrei doctrine is the structure of the sengū hypothesis applied to the sovereign body.

The architecture of Ise itself encodes a further, decisive element. The sacred precinct comprises two adjacent plots. On one stands the current shrine; the other, the vacant site (*kodenchi*), awaits the next reconstruction, and at its centre, sheltered by a small hut, remains the site of the hidden heart pillar (*shin no mihashira*), which no one is permitted to see. The sacred centre of Ise thus alternates between presence and absence, and even when present it is organised around a concealed column. The same structure recurs in Mishima's sacred geography. The Ōmiwa shrine at the foot of Mount Miwa, where Honda first sees Isao in *Runaway Horses*, has no main sanctuary at all: the mountain is the god, and the worshipper faces a void framed by a gate. Throughout the corpus the sacred centre is a vacancy that authorises.

7.4

Three Empty Centres: Maruyama, Barthes, Mishima

The figure of the empty centre was, in the years around 1970, the common property of three incompatible theories. For Maruyama Masao, in the essays of 1946–1949 that founded postwar political science in Japan, the imperial system had generated a system of irresponsibility: authority flowed from proximity to an Emperor who was himself not a deciding subject but the embodiment of an inherited tradition, so that the war had been made by a structure in which no one decided. The empty centre was

a political pathology. For Roland Barthes, in *L'Empire des signes* (1970), Tokyo presented the precious paradox of a city that possesses a centre which is empty: the forbidden, indifferent precinct of the imperial palace, around which the city turns without ever entering it. The empty centre was a semiotic liberation, the model of a signification freed from the tyranny of the signified. For Mishima the empty centre was a sacred void whose vacancy had been desecrated: the void that authorises, which the postwar order had converted into a void that merely remains vacant, filled by the mass-mediated image of a constitutional symbol.

The three readings share a structure and divide on its valence, and their juxtaposition clarifies what was at stake in 1970. Maruyama's reading explains why an appeal to the Emperor could not be answered by any responsible agent; Barthes's reading explains why the appeal would be received as a sign among signs; and Mishima's reading explains why, for him, only an act that filled the vacancy with a real death could restore its sacred character. The act would make the empty centre bleed.

7.5

Kojève's Japan and the Promise That Cannot Be Kept

In the note added to the second edition of his *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel* (1962), Alexandre Kojève recorded the impression left by a journey to Japan in 1959. Japan, he wrote, had lived for almost three centuries in the condition that Hegel's philosophy of history had predicted for mankind at the end of history: a life without war or revolution, in which negating action had been replaced by the cultivation of pure forms—the Nō theatre, the tea ceremony, the art of flower arrangement—which Kojève called snobbery in its pure state. In such a society, he observed, a person might commit a perfectly gratuitous suicide out of pure snobbery, as a formal act emptied of historical content; and he predicted that the interaction between Japan and the West would end not in the Westernisation of Japan but in the Japanisation of the West.

On 7 July 1970, in an essay in the *Sankei shinbun* titled "Hatashienai yakusoku" ("The Promise I Cannot Keep"), Mishima reviewed the twenty-five years since the war and predicted that Japan would disappear, to be replaced by an inorganic, empty, neutral, intermediate, affluent, and shrewd economic power in a corner of the Far East, with whose people he declared he had no wish to speak. The essay is Kojève's diagnosis rendered as lament. Japanese social theory has since given it a periodisation. Mita Munesuke divided the postwar into an age of ideals, an

age of dreams, and an age of fiction; Ōsawa Masachi revised the scheme so that the age of ideals ends and the age of fiction begins in 1970, and the age of fiction ends in 1995. On this periodisation Mishima's death falls exactly on the threshold at which the ideal gives way to the fictional, and it may be read as the last act of the age of ideals performed in the idiom of the age of fiction.

The debate Mishima held on 13 May 1969 with roughly a thousand students of the radical Zenkyōtō at the Komaba campus of the University of Tokyo, published the same year and revisited in a documentary of 2020, shows that the diagnosis was shared across the political spectrum. The students and their antagonist agreed that the postwar order was a closure to be broken; they disagreed on the name of what would break it. Mishima told them that if they would only speak the word Emperor, he would join them. The Emperor was, for him, the name of the outside of posthistory; for them it was the name of posthistory's oldest ideological support.

7.6

The Emperor as Ise

The political theology of the empty centre can now be restated in the terms of the sengū hypothesis. Mishima's Emperor is a form renewed through the succession of its bearers, each of whom is the Emperor as such, as each rebuilt shrine is Ise as such. The Humanity Declaration threatened this structure at its source, since in it the bearer declared himself merely a bearer, a man and not the form: the replica announced that it was only a replica. The refrain of *Eirei no koe* is the lament of a theology whose copy has renounced its claim to be the original. The appeal of 25 November, which ended with the traditional acclamation of the Emperor, was addressed to an Emperor who had declared himself human; it was an appeal to a copy to become, once more, an original, and it proposed to effect the restoration by a sacrifice that would make the vacant centre bleed. Whether a sacrifice could accomplish this is precisely the question the tetralogy had been posing for five years, and to which, as Part III will show, its final page had already returned a negative answer.

PART III

Speculations

The hypothesis carried into cosmic fiction, tested to destruction, and theorised as posthistorical tragedy.

08 Epitaphic Humanism

09 The Storehouse and the Ocean

10 The Last Instant

11 The Copy That Bleeds

CHAPTER EIGHT

Epitaphic Humanism

Beautiful Star *and the Cosmic Gaze*

8.1

A Family from Other Planets

Utsukushii hoshi (*Beautiful Star*, 1962; trans. Stephen Dodd, 2022) is the work in which Mishima's speculative imagination is most openly declared and, for that reason, the one that criticism has most often treated as an eccentricity. Its protagonists are an ordinary family in the provincial town of Hannō, west of Tokyo, each of whom, after witnessing unidentified flying objects, awakens to the conviction of an extraterrestrial origin: the father, Ōsugi Jūichirō, from Mars; the mother, Iyoko, from Jupiter; the son, Kazuo, from Mercury; the daughter, Akiko, from Venus. Living outwardly as before, they form an association to save humanity from nuclear self-destruction, and Jūichirō writes to Khrushchev urging an end to the atmospheric tests that the Soviet Union had resumed in 1961, the year of the largest thermonuclear detonation in history. The domestic comedy is interwoven with the geopolitics of the Berlin crisis and the approach of the Cuban crisis, and with a subplot in which Akiko, travelling to Kanazawa to meet a young man who also claims Venusian origin, becomes pregnant by him before he vanishes.

Mishima's interest in the subject was not merely literary. He was a member of the Japan Flying Saucer Research Association, founded in 1955, and he watched the night sky for saucers. But the novel neither endorses nor ridicules its characters' convictions. It sustains, to its final page, exactly the hesitation that Todorov made the criterion of the fan-

tastic: the reader is never permitted to decide whether the Ōsugis are visitors from other planets or a family that has found in cosmic identity a refuge from the terror of the nuclear age. In this respect *Beautiful Star* is unique in the corpus. It is the one work in which Mishima refuses to test his novum, and its refusal is the condition of its tenderness.

The identities the family adopt are themselves instances of iconic anteriority. Each member becomes who he or she is by identifying with an image—a light in the sky, a planetary name—that precedes and reorganises the self. The cosmic identity is a mask in the sense of *Kamen no kokuhaku*: not a disguise over a true face but the only face available, and one that, adopted in full seriousness, confers a view of the earth from outside.

8.2

The Grand Inquisitor in Hannō

The novel's philosophical centre is a long debate between Jūichirō and his antagonist, Haguro Mokichi, a provincial university lecturer who, with two companions, a bank clerk and a barber, believes himself to originate from a planet in the system of 61 Cygni and to have been sent to hasten humanity's extinction. The debate consciously recalls the Grand Inquisitor episode of Dostoevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880). Haguro argues that human beings are incapable of bearing their own freedom, that their history is a sequence of evasions culminating in a weapon adequate to their self-hatred, and that their annihilation would be an act of mercy. Jūichirō, who cannot refute him on the plane of argument, answers on another plane altogether. He composes, in the voice of an extraterrestrial observer after humanity's disappearance, an epitaph for the human race.

The epitaph praises nothing that humanism has traditionally praised. It does not commemorate reason, art, science, or moral progress. It records instead a handful of minor habits: that human beings decorated their lives with flowers on occasions of joy and of mourning, that they kept small birds, that they were often late for their appointments, and that they laughed a great deal. It closes with the wish that their eternal sleep be peaceful. In Dostoevsky, Christ answers the Inquisitor's argument with a silent kiss, a gesture that refutes nothing and yet overturns everything. Jūichirō's epitaph occupies the place of the kiss. It concedes the Inquisitor's premise—humanity is doomed—and loves humanity as already dead.

8.3

Epitaphic Humanism

The stance may be defined as the love of the human from the standpoint of its completed extinction. Humanity, in the epitaph, is a finished form: seen whole, from outside history, as one sees a building that has burned or a life that has ended. What is valued is precisely what could not be valued from within history, where every trivial grace is subordinated to projects and outcomes. Only from the standpoint of the epitaph can lateness appear as charm and laughter as a monument.

The structure is identical to that of *Kinkakuji*. Mizoguchi can possess the pavilion only as destroyed; Jūichirō can love humanity only as extinct. The two works, written six years apart, compose a diptych in which the same operation is performed on a building and on a species, and the diptych discloses an ambivalence at the heart of Mishima's humanism that criticism has not sufficiently confronted. The trivial graces of the epitaph—flowers, birds, lateness, laughter—are exactly the substance of the everyday postwar life that the essay of July 1970 would dismiss as inorganic, empty, and neutral. Mishima's tenderest page and his bitterest page describe the same world; the difference lies wholly in the standpoint. Seen from within, the everyday is the posthistorical vacuity that must be broken; seen from after its end, it is the only thing worth commemorating. Epitaphic humanism thus contains, in compressed form, the double ending of 1970: it can affirm the ordinary only on condition of its annihilation, and it can annihilate only what it has already learned to mourn.

The cosmic gaze is the gaze of the posthumous. The Ōsugis see the earth as the survivor of 1945 saw postwar Japan: from a position already outside the life being regarded. *Beautiful Star* is the most generous expression of that position, because it converts the survivor's estrangement into an act of care. It is also the most dangerous, because the care it expresses is inseparable from the imagination of extinction, and because it teaches that love reaches its object only across the gap of an ending.

8.4

Cosmic Comparisons

Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) had already given epitaphic humanism its classical form. Its eighteenth and last human species, facing extinction on Neptune as the sun is destroyed, composes a message to

the first men that affirms the whole two-billion-year history of the species as a work of art; in the Last Men's words, man is a fair spirit, and the book ends with the declaration that it is very good to have been man. *Star Maker* (1937) extended the gaze to the cosmos, culminating in a vision of a creator who regards his creations not with pity but with the contemplative delight of an artist, and whose indifference the narrator finds himself compelled to worship. Stapledon's cosmic aestheticism and Jūichirō's epitaph share a premise: that the value of the human can be seen only from the standpoint of a completed history. They differ in scale and in temper. Stapledon's epitaph is spoken by the last human beings about themselves; Mishima's is spoken by an alien, or by a man who has made himself one.

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) supplies the figure of the last witness. Its humanity is transformed into a collective mind and departs the earth, and the final human being, Jan Rodricks, who has returned from the Overlords' distant world, describes the planet's dissolution to the departing Overlords until the transmission ceases. Jan anticipates Honda, the witness who survives the incarnations he records and whose testimony ends in a vanishing. Kurt Vonnegut's *Cat's Cradle* (1963), published the year after *Beautiful Star*, ends the world by a substance that freezes all water, and closes with the testament of the prophet Bokonon, who declares that were he younger he would write a history of human stupidity, climb a mountain, and make of himself, with the fatal ice, a statue lying on its back and thumbing its nose at God. Vonnegut's joke is the most succinct formulation in postwar fiction of thanatoplasty: the last human act is to convert oneself into a monument of defiance. What Vonnegut offers as black comedy, Mishima would perform without irony.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) supplies the counter-case. The happiness of Le Guin's utopian city depends on the suffering of a single child confined in a cellar, and the story honours those citizens who, having seen the child, walk away. Mishima's theory of culture, formulated in *Bunka bōeiron*, is the theory of Omelas affirmed: form is preserved by the periodic sacrifice of its bearers, and the beauty of the city is inseparable from the cellar. Le Guin's walkers refuse the sacrificial economy; Mishima's heroes embrace it, and *The Sea of Fertility* will be the work in which the economy is audited.

The Japanese tradition offers two further comparisons. Abe Kōbō's *Dai-yon kanpyōki* (*Inter Ice Age* 4, 1959) imagines a forecasting machine that reveals a future in which the earth is submerged and humanity has been succeeded by gilled beings bred for the sea; the scientist who can-

not accept that future is judged by it and condemned as obsolete. The present is regarded from its posterity and found already dead. Komatsu Sakyō's *Nihon chinbotsu* (*Japan Sinks*, 1973), published three years after Mishima's death, imagines the sinking of the archipelago and the dispersal of its people, and gives to an aged patron the thought that it might be better for the Japanese to perish with their islands. Komatsu's novel poses, in geological terms, the sengū question in its most extreme form: can a form survive the destruction of its entire material bearer? Komatsu's answer, pursued in the diaspora of his sequel, is a qualified yes. Mishima's answer, as the next chapter will show, was no.

8.5

The Dry Sea

The title of the tetralogy extends the cosmic gaze to the moon. *Hōjō no umi* translates *Mare Fecunditatis*, the Sea of Fertility, a dark basaltic plain on the lunar surface that early astronomers took for water; Mishima explained that he intended the title to evoke precisely this arid sea, named for an abundance it does not possess. The title thus contains the ending in advance: a fertility that is a desert, a sea without water, a plenitude that is a name. In September 1970, two months before the delivery of the final instalment, the Soviet probe Luna 16 landed in Mare Fecunditatis and returned to earth a little over a hundred grams of its dust. It is difficult to imagine a more exact charcoal scuttle for the tetralogy's cosmology: the Sea of Fertility, visited at last, yielded a handful of dry regolith. *Beautiful Star* had looked at the earth from space and loved it as a grave. *The Sea of Fertility* would look at the whole chain of human transmission from the standpoint of its end and find, in the garden where the chain terminates, the lunar sea: a name for fullness, and nothing.

CHAPTER NINE

The Storehouse and the Ocean

The Sea of Fertility *as Speculative Ontology*

9.1

Four Incarnations, One Witness

Hōjō no umi was serialised in the monthly *Shinchō* from September 1965 to January 1971 and published in four volumes between 1969 and 1971. A note appended to *Haru no yuki* declares that the work is a tale of dreams and reincarnation drawing on the late-Heian *Hamamatsu Chūnagon monogatari*, and that its title renders the Latin name of one of the lunar seas. Mishima's own gloss on the design associated its volumes with the four aspects of the soul in Shintō doctrine—the gentle, the rough, the wondrous, and the blessing soul (*nigimitama*, *aramitama*, *kushimitama*, *sakimitama*)—and the first two with the feminine and masculine styles of nativist poetics. The architecture is that of an experiment with four trials and a single observer.

THE FOUR TRIALS · VOLUMES, INCARNATIONS, AND ENDINGS

01 *Haru no yuki* — *Spring Snow*, 1969	
INCARNATION	Matsugae Kiyoaki
ACTION	1912–1914, Tokyo and Nara
MODE	Courtly passion (*taoyameburi*; *nigimitama*)
END AT TWENTY	Dies of illness after the snowbound vigil at Gesshūji
PRINCIPAL SOURCES	*Hamamatsu Chūnagon monogatari*; the Heian romance; the Tristan myth

02 *Honba* *Runaway Horses*, 1969	INCARNATION	Iinuma Isao
	ACTION	1932–1933, Tokyo, Nara, Ise
	MODE	Loyalist action (*masuraoburi*; *aramitama*)
	END AT TWENTY	Seppuku after an assassination, in his twentieth year
	PRINCIPAL SOURCES	Shinpūren; Yōmeigaku; *Hagakure*; Kusunoki's vow
03 *Akatsuki no tera* *The Temple of Dawn*, 1970	INCARNATION	Ying Chan (Jin Jan), a Thai princess
	ACTION	1940–1952, Bangkok, India, Gotemba
	MODE	The observed body (*kushimitama*)
	END AT TWENTY	Dies of a cobra bite, reported afterward
	PRINCIPAL SOURCES	Yogācāra; Theravāda Siam; Benares and Ajanta
04 *Tennin gosui* *The Decay of the Angel*, 1971	INCARNATION	Yasunaga Tōru
	ACTION	1970–1975, Shimizu, Tokyo, Nara
	MODE	Counterfeit cognition (*sakimitama*, by design)
	END AT TWENTY	Fails to die; survives blinded
	PRINCIPAL SOURCES	The five signs of a deva's decay; the forged copy

The single observer is Honda Shigekuni, Kiyoaki's schoolfriend, who becomes successively a magistrate, a lawyer, a rich man, and an old one. At the end of *Spring Snow* the dying Kiyoaki promises that they will meet again beneath a waterfall; eighteen years later, at the foot of Mount Miwa, Honda sees beneath the three waterfalls a young kendo champion bearing, under the left armpit, the three small moles that had marked Kiyoaki's body. The rest of the tetralogy is Honda's investigation, conducted with the scruple of a jurist, into whether the moles constitute evidence. Kiyoaki's dream diary, entrusted to Honda, supplies a second line of proof, since its dreams anticipate the lives that follow; the deaths at twenty supply a third. Each volume is a trial of the hypothesis, and each trial is recorded by the one man who has seen them all.

The arithmetic of the design carries a biographical charge that has not, to the present writer's knowledge, been sufficiently emphasised. Mishima was born in January 1925. When he appeared for his conscription physical in February 1945 and was sent home, he was twenty years old. The tetralogy's heroes die at the age at which their author was spared, and its

fourth volume is the story of a young man who fails to die at twenty and survives into a degraded life. The reincarnations stage, four times, the death that the author missed; the witness who survives them stages the author's survival.

9.2

Sources: Heian Romance, Loyalist Vow, Buddhist Psychology

Three traditions of transmigration converge in the design. The *Hamamatsu Chūnagon monogatari*, an eleventh-century romance attributed to the author of the *Sarashina nikki*, supplies the literary form: a hero whose dead father is reborn as a Chinese prince, and a narrative in which dreams announce rebirths across the sea. Kusunoki Masashige's vow to be reborn seven times for the court, discussed in Chapter 3, supplies the political form: rebirth as the renewal of fidelity in successive bodies. The Yogācāra school of Mahāyāna Buddhism supplies the philosophical form, and it does so with a technical precision that makes *The Temple of Dawn* one of the most ambitious philosophical novels of the century.

Yogācāra, systematised by Asaṅga and Vasubandhu in the fourth and fifth centuries and transmitted to East Asia through Xuanzang's *Cheng weishi lun* (659), the foundational text of the Hossō school, holds that the world is representation only (*vijñaptimātra*). Beneath the six forms of consciousness—the five senses and the mind—lies a seventh, the afflicted mind (*manas*) that mistakes the eighth for a self, and the eighth, the storehouse consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*), in which the seeds (*bīja*) deposited by every act, through a process of perfuming (*vāsanā*), await their ripening into new experience. The storehouse is not a substance. It is momentary, arising and perishing in every instant, and Vasubandhu's *Triṃśikā* describes it as proceeding like a torrent. Seed and manifestation cause one another simultaneously: seeds produce the manifest world, and the manifest world perfumes new seeds, in the same instant. Liberation is a transformation of the basis (*āśraya-parāvṛtti*), in which the storehouse, emptied of the defilement that took it for a self, becomes the Great Mirror Wisdom (*ādarśa-jñāna*), a knowing that reflects everything and retains nothing.

Honda's study of these doctrines, pursued through the Indian journey of *The Temple of Dawn* and the reading of the Hossō treatises, among other materials on rebirth, culminates in a figure that the tetralogy has

been preparing since its first volume. The storehouse consciousness is like a waterfall: its form persists, while the water that composes it is never for an instant the same. Kiyoaki's promise to meet beneath a waterfall, Isao's discovery beneath the falls of Miwa, the waterfall Honda contemplates at Ajanta—the recurrent image is the figure of identity through continuous replacement.

9.3

The Ālaya as the Ise of the Mind

The figure reveals the metaphysical core of the tetralogy. The waterfall is the sengū at infinite frequency. Ise renews its form by destroying its material bearer every twenty years; the storehouse consciousness renews its form by destroying its bearer in every instant. The reincarnations, dying at twenty, stand exactly between the two scales: they are the Ise cycle made of persons, and they are also, on Yogācāra premises, simply a coarse-grained visibility of what occurs continuously and invisibly in every mind. The tetralogy's decision to ground its novum in Yogācāra is therefore not an exotic ornament but the consequence of its own hypothesis pushed to the limit. And at the limit the hypothesis undoes itself. If form persists only through destruction and renewal, and if destruction and renewal occur in every instant, then there is at no moment an original to be copied: every state of the stream is the copy of a copy, and the question whether the fourth incarnation is identical with the first has no determinate answer, because the first was never identical with itself.

The tetralogy's evidentiary apparatus registers this dissolution with a rigour that may be expressed in the vocabulary of Charles Sanders Peirce. The three moles are offered as an index: a sign connected to its object by physical contiguity, a trace that the soul leaves on successive bodies as a footprint is left by a foot. But a mark on the skin can also be an icon, a sign that merely resembles its object, and nothing in the moles themselves distinguishes the one from the other. As the incarnations succeed one another, the index degrades into the icon. Kiyoaki's moles are simply his; Isao's are a revelation; Ying Chan's are glimpsed by a voyeur through a hole in a library wall; Tōru's are those of an orphan whose date of birth cannot be established and whom Honda adopts because the resemblance is enough. The sign that was to connect the chain becomes, by the end, a similarity from which the connection has vanished. It is precisely here that the text's own terms of reference acquire their full sense: a copy that bleeds would be an icon that is also an index. The tetralogy is the demon-

stration that the two can be told apart only by a witness, and that the witness cannot tell them apart.

9.4

The Four Trials

Spring Snow conducts the trial of eros. Kiyoaki's passion for Satoko, kindled by the imperial sanction of her betrothal, consummated in violation of it, and ended by her tonsure at Gesshūji and his death after waiting vainly in the snow for admission, is the perfect Tristan of the Taishō aristocracy. The Siamese princes who visit the Matsugae household, and the emerald ring one of them loses, seed the third volume. The dream diary seeds the whole.

Runaway Horses conducts the trial of action. Isao, who has studied the history of the Shinpūren until he wishes to repeat it, plots with a band of students to assassinate the financiers he holds responsible for the nation's corruption; he is betrayed, arrested, and tried, and Honda resigns his judgeship to defend him. Released, Isao stabs to death the financier Kurahara Busuke, who is reported to have profaned the Grand Shrine of Ise, and flees to a cliff above the sea, where he commits seppuku before dawn. At the moment of death, the novel tells us, the sun rose bright behind his closed eyelids. The sentence has been read as apotheosis. It is more exactly a refutation. The night is still dark; the sun that rises is an image produced by the dying body, and the real death, the most real of all events, yields at its culmination not the real but a representation. The novel of action ends by showing that action at its limit generates an image.

The Temple of Dawn conducts the trial of cognition. In Bangkok in 1940 a seven-year-old princess insists that she is Japanese and recalls events from Isao's life; Honda travels through India, observes the cremations at Benares and the caves of Ajanta, and immerses himself in the theory of rebirth. After the war, rich from a lawsuit, he builds a villa beneath Mount Fuji, and when the princess, now eighteen, comes to study in Japan, he watches her through a spy-hole in the wall of his library in the hope of seeing the moles. He sees them. The villa burns. Years later he learns that she died at twenty of a cobra bite. The witness has become a voyeur, and the voyeurism is not an accident of character but the logical form of pure cognition: to see without acting, to know without participating, to verify the hypothesis at the cost of reducing its object to a spectacle.

The Decay of the Angel conducts the trial of the copy. Tōru, a sixteen-year-old orphan working at a signal station on the coast at Shimizu, where he observes ships through a telescope, bears the three moles, and Honda adopts him as his heir. He proves to be cold, calculating, and cruel, and when Honda's friend Keiko reveals to him the history of the incarnations and suggests that he may be counterfeit, he burns Kiyoaki's dream diary—the copy destroys the record of the original—and at twenty attempts to kill himself by drinking methanol; the attempt fails and leaves him blind. He survives, married to a deluded girl convinced of her own beauty. The title names the five signs of a heavenly being's decline recorded in Genshin's *Ōjōyōshū* (985): the withering of the flowers in its headdress, the soiling of its robes, sweat from its armpits, the dimming of its radiance, and its loss of delight in its seat. *Tennin*, the heavenly being, and *tennō*, the heavenly sovereign, share the character for heaven, and the decay of the one is legible, on the terms established in Chapter 7, as the decay of the other.

The four trials may accordingly be read as four phases of the imperial form. Kiyoaki belongs to the Emperor of courtly elegance, the source of the interdict whose violation made eros absolute. Isao belongs to the Emperor of the 1930s, the object of a lethal loyalty that the living sovereign condemned. Ying Chan belongs to the Emperor displaced abroad, the form carried into empire and defeat and reincarnated in the body of a foreign princess. Tōru belongs to the postwar Emperor, the adopted heir, the mass-mediated symbol, the watcher of ships who is suspected of being a copy. The decay of the angel is the decay of the heavenly sovereign into his replica.

9.5

The Garden at Noon

In the summer of 1975, ill and eighty-one, Honda returns to Gesshūji, where in 1914 he had pleaded in vain on behalf of the dying Kiyoaki. The abbess who receives him is Satoko, eighty-three. She listens to his account of Kiyoaki and professes to have no knowledge of such a person; she suggests, with serene courtesy, that perhaps there never was a Kiyoaki, and wonders whether there was ever a Honda; memory, she implies, is a phantom mirror. She then shows him the south garden, which is empty in the sun, and the novel ends with Honda's recognition that he has come to a place without memory, where there is nothing.

The scene has been read as betrayal, as senile forgetfulness, as Buddhist consolation, and as nihilist collapse. Read with Yogācāra, it is none of these. Satoko is the abbess of a Hossō convent, and she speaks from the standpoint that Hossō doctrine names the transformation of the basis. For the Great Mirror Wisdom, which reflects all things and retains none, the chain of seeds that Honda has spent sixty years documenting was never a substance; the storehouse, emptied of the defilement that took it for a self, holds no memory because there was never anyone to whom the memory belonged. Honda's empirical project is refuted by the very doctrine he had used to support it. The garden, in the terms of Chapter 7, is Ise's vacant plot: the site where the next shrine would stand, from which the building has been removed and on which nothing will be built. The sengū stops. The hypothesis that form survives through the destruction of its bearers is falsified at the moment its witness arrives at the origin and finds the origin denied.

Marcel Proust's À *la recherche du temps perdu* ends, in *Le Temps retrouvé* (1927), with the narrator's discovery through involuntary memory that lost time is recoverable in art, and with his decision to write the book the reader has just read. *The Sea of Fertility* is the anti-*Temps retrouvé*: memory is not recovered but disavowed, the chronicler finds at the source not his past but its absence, and no book is to be written, since the one person who could write it has just been told that its subject may never have existed.

9.6

Comparisons: Copies without Originals

The ontological fictions of the twentieth century offer a series of solutions to the problem the tetralogy poses, and their differences locate Mishima's precisely. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) imagines a planetary ocean that fashions, from the memories of the scientists orbiting it, material replicas of the persons they have lost. Kelvin's replica of his dead wife, Harey, suffers, learns that she is a copy, tries to destroy herself by drinking liquid oxygen, regenerates, and finally consents to her own annihilation; Kelvin remains on the planet in the hope that the age of cruel miracles has not passed. Lem's ocean is an *ālaya* made planetary, a storehouse that produces representations from the seeds of memory, and Harey is the copy that bleeds realised: her suffering makes her a person, and her personhood is tragic. In Lem the copy that bleeds is possible. In Mishima, it is precisely what the last page denies.

Adolfo Bioy Casares's *La invención de Morel* (1940), whose plot Borges's prologue praised as perfect, imagines a machine that records a week of human life and projects it eternally, killing those it records. The fugitive narrator, in love with the projected image of Faustine, records himself into the loop so as to share her eternity, and dies of the recording, begging some future inventor to unite his consciousness with hers. No text in the literature of the century states the logic of thanatoplasty more completely: one enters the image by dying, and the image one becomes is a copy that no longer knows it bleeds. Jorge Luis Borges supplies the metaphysics in three variations. In "Las ruinas circulares" (1940) a magician who dreams a man into being walks into fire, is not burned, and understands that he too is dreamed: the originator discovers that he is a copy. In "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) the *hrönir*, objects produced by expectation, grow purer in each generation of copying, so that the copy surpasses the original. In "El inmortal" (1947) the immortal, having lived long enough to be every man, is no one; identity extended across endless rebirth dissolves into anonymity, which is exactly the verdict Satoko pronounces on the chain of incarnations.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) sets an activist psychiatrist, Haber, who uses his patient's world-altering dreams to engineer a better world, against the patient, Orr, whose Taoist passivity is vindicated when it emerges that the world itself is already a dream dreamed back into being after a catastrophe: the present is a copy whose original was destroyed. Haber is the Yōmei activist, Orr the Buddhist witness, and Le Guin, unlike Mishima, lets the witness save the world by refusing to act on it. Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962), set in an America partitioned by the victorious Axis, contains the century's most economical parable of copy and original: two identical cigarette lighters, one of which was in Roosevelt's pocket when he was assassinated, distinguishable only by an invisible property the novel calls historicity. Dick's Japanese collectors of American antiques, perpetually anxious about forgeries, are Kojève's snobs, and the novel's inner fiction, composed with the aid of the *I Ching*, reveals that the world of the novel is itself the counterfeit of another. Historicity is the property Mishima's moles were meant to certify and could not. Murakami Haruki's *Sekai no owari to hādoboirudo wandārando* (*Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World*, 1985), finally, sets within its narrator's mind a walled town where a dreamreader reads old dreams from the skulls of unicorns, and ends with the narrator's choice to remain inside the world his consciousness has made. Murakami's closed storehouse yields an ethic of quiet responsibility for

one's own representations. Mishima's yields a garden in which there is nothing to be responsible for.

These comparisons clarify the singularity of the tetralogy's contribution to speculative fiction. Where Lem makes the copy tragic, Bioy Casares makes it fatal, Borges makes it infinite, Le Guin makes it redemptive, Dick makes it political, and Murakami makes it habitable, Mishima makes it vanish. His is the only one of these fictions whose final move is the withdrawal of the original itself, performed by a witness of the origin, in the vocabulary of a doctrine that had been the fiction's own theoretical support. It is in this sense that *The Sea of Fertility* constitutes a Buddhist-nativist contribution to the ontological turn in speculative fiction: it brings a nativist hypothesis of transmission and a Buddhist analysis of consciousness into a single experimental design, and it lets the second falsify the first.

9.7

The Author among His Incarnations

Mishima invited his readers to map him onto his characters, and the invitation, accepted with caution, yields a final structural observation. He was Honda by fate: the survivor and witness, the man of cognition who outlived the deaths he recorded. He was Isao by aspiration: the man of action whose death he rehearsed in *Yūkoku* and would perform at Ichigaya in Isao's manner. By the arithmetic of age he was Tōru: forty-five and not twenty, the belated incarnation whose attempt to die at the appointed moment could only be a copy of the deaths that had preceded it. The fourth volume, completed before the act, had already described what the act would be. In November 1970 Mishima delivered to his publisher the story of a counterfeit who fails to die at the appointed time and of a witness who discovers that the chain has no origin, and then went to Ichigaya to die as the original.

CHAPTER TEN

The Last Instant

Glory, Nihilism, and the Speculative Moment

10.1

Kyōko's House: Four Postwar Nihilisms

The ambition of *Kyōko no ie* (*Kyōko's House*, 1959) was to write the history of an era's nihilism, and its cool reception marked, by Mishima's own account, a turning point after which the body and politics displaced the novel as the privileged instruments of his thought. Its four young men gather in the salon of a wealthy divorcée whose name contains the character for mirror, and each reflects a facet of their author. Shunkichi, a boxer, is the man of action; when an injury ends his career, he drifts into a right-wing association. Natsuo, a painter, is the man of sensibility, who loses and slowly recovers his hold on the visible world. Osamu, an actor who builds his body with weights, is the man of self-consciousness: he enters a sadomasochistic affair with the moneylender to whom his mother is indebted, in which, at his urging, she cuts him, and his story ends in their double suicide. Seiichirō, a salaried employee of a trading firm, is the most original figure: convinced that the world is about to end, he conforms flawlessly to its demands, since nothing he does can matter. The novel is set in the mid-1950s, the years in which an official economic white paper (1956) declared that Japan was no longer in the postwar, and Seiichirō is the portrait of the subject for whom that declaration is true. He is Kojève's posthistorical man before Kojève's note was written: a person whose perfect adherence to form is the expression of a perfect indifference to content.

The four figures map the options available after the end of history. Action without a cause becomes political romanticism; sensibility without a world becomes mysticism; self-consciousness without an exit seeks proof in the wound and ends in a staged death; and nihilism without despair becomes conformity. Mishima's subsequent career can be read as the attempt to combine the first three—the boxer, the painter, and the actor—against the fourth. What the novel already suggests, however, is that the fourth absorbs the others. Seiichirō's conviction that the world has ended is the premise of all their gestures, and the salon of the mirror reflects each of them back to him as a variation on his indifference.

10.2

The Modern Nō: Seeing the End of the World

The modern Nō plays condense the same structure into single instants. In *Sotoba Komachi*, collected in *Kindai nōgakushū* (*Five Modern Nō Plays*, 1956), a young poet in a city park meets an ancient woman who once was the beauty Komachi; transported with her into a remembered ball of the Rokumeikan era, he calls her beautiful, and the utterance kills him, since whoever pronounces her beautiful must die. The word of beauty is itself the instrument of death, and the drama is iconic anteriority in the performative mode: the image, once spoken, consumes the speaker. *Yoroboshi* (1960), a later addition to the cycle, adapts the Nō in which a blind boy contemplates the setting sun at the Shitennōji temple in Osaka, where the meditation on the western sun opens toward the Pure Land. Mishima's blind youth lost his sight in the firebombing of 1945 and insists that he then saw the end of the world, a conflagration he describes as a sunset; everything that has happened since, for him, is its afterglow. The postwar is not a new beginning but the aftermath of an apocalypse already witnessed, and the only true vision was the last one.

10.3

The Sailor Who Fell from Grace with the Sea: Glory and the Bitter Tea

Gogo no eikō (1963; *The Sailor Who Fell from Grace with the Sea*, trans. John Nathan, 1965) is the most perfectly constructed of Mishima's shorter novels and the most concentrated statement of the aesthetics of the last instant. Noboru, thirteen, lives in Yokohama with his widowed mother, Fusako, and spies on her bedroom through a hole in the wall of his chest

of drawers. When she takes as her lover the ship's officer Tsukazaki Ryūji, Noboru sees in the sailor the embodiment of the sea's glory: a man destined for some great and fatal distinction. Noboru belongs to a gang of boys led by a precocious nihilist, the chief, who teaches that the world is empty, that adults are contemptible, and that only acts of perfect hardness possess reality; the boys prove their doctrine by killing and dissecting a kitten. When Ryūji resolves to leave the sea, marry Fusako, and become a shopkeeper, the boys judge that he has fallen from glory and must be restored to it by death. They lure him to a hillside and give him drugged tea, intending to kill and dissect him as they did the kitten, and the novel ends as he drinks, reflecting that glory, as everyone knows, is bitter. The Japanese title plays on a homophone: *eikō* means both the towing of a ship and glory.

The boys' logic is thanatoplasty applied to another. Like Mizoguchi, who could possess the pavilion only by burning it, they can preserve Ryūji's image only by destroying his body before the body betrays it. Their nihilism is posthistorical in the precise sense of this thesis: for them the world has ended, all values are forms, and the only remaining act is the preservation of an image by the annihilation of its bearer. The peephole through which Noboru watches is the organ of the whole enterprise. From it descend Honda's spy-hole in the library at Gotemba and Tōru's telescope at the signal station: in Mishima, cognition is voyeurism, and voyeurism is the condition of a glory that can only be seen, never lived.

The comparative frame sharpens the portrait. William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) discovers in its boys the savagery of nature beneath civilisation; Anthony Burgess's A *Clockwork Orange* (1962) discovers in its adolescent aesthete of violence the problem of freedom; Jean Cocteau's *Les Enfants terribles* (1929) discovers in its enclosed siblings an aesthetic of the closed room that culminates in death as the game's conclusion. Mishima's boys are closest to Cocteau's, but their closed room is metaphysical: it is the world after its end, and the game they play in it is the conversion of a living man into a monument of his own glory.

10.4
The Phosphene Sun

The last instant recurs throughout the corpus as an instant of total vision, and in its most important instance the vision is of the sun. Isao's death at the end of *Runaway Horses* is accompanied by a sun that rises behind his closed eyelids while the sky is still dark. Albert Camus's *L'Étranger* (1942)

had made the sun the absurd cause of its hero's crime: the glare on the beach, the flash on the blade, the heat that presses Meursault toward the shot he cannot explain. Camus's sun is the real, indifferent and overwhelming, which drives the subject to an act without meaning; Mishima's sun is an image produced by the subject at the moment of an act saturated with meaning. The two suns frame the alternative within which the aesthetics of the last instant moves. Either the act is caused by a real that exceeds it, or it causes an image that replaces the real.

Camus's political writings provide the ethical counterpart. In *Les Justes* (1949), and in the chapter of *L'Homme révolté* (1951) devoted to the fastidious assassins, Camus honoured the Russian terrorist Ivan Kaliayev, who refused to throw his bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage when he saw children inside, killed the Grand Duke Sergei Alexandrovich with a bomb two days later, in February 1905, and accepted execution, by hanging that May, as the price of the life he had taken. For Camus the rebel who kills must acknowledge a limit, and *L'Homme révolté* ends with an invocation of the thought of noon, the Mediterranean measure that refuses the absolute. Isao, who kills and dies, is a fastidious assassin in form; but his act acknowledges no limit, since its measure is not the life taken but the purity of the one who takes it. The thought of noon will return in the Conclusion, where it meets another noon.

Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–1872) supplies the most prophetic analysis of the metaphysical suicide's fate. Kirillov intends to take his own life for no reason at all, to demonstrate that man is free because God does not exist, and the revolutionary conspirator Pyotr Verkhovensky, learning of his intention, arranges that before shooting himself he sign a confession to a murder the conspirators have committed. The purest possible act, an act of self-assertion that was to have no purpose beyond itself, is appropriated by a political machine and converted into an alibi. Kirillov's fate is the fate of every death that aspires to signify only itself: its meaning is expropriated by whoever controls the story told about it. The posthumous history of 25 November—annexed by the nationalist right as martyrdom, by the state as madness, by the media as spectacle, by criticism as symptom—is Kirillov's fate multiplied.

10.5

The Secret Miracle and the Inaudible Speech

Jorge Luis Borges's "El milagro secreto" (1943) imagines a Czech playwright, Jaromir Hladík, condemned to be shot by the occupying Germans, who asks God for a year in which to finish his play. The year is granted between the order to fire and the impact of the bullets: time stops, and Hladík composes and revises the entire work in his mind, perfecting every line, before the volley ends his life. The play exists, complete, and no one will ever read it. The instant has been given its fullest content and denied every form of transmission.

The balcony at Ichigaya reverses the miracle. Mishima had prepared a speech to be delivered at the culmination of his life, before an audience of soldiers who were to be moved by it to act. The speech was delivered, and it could not be heard: the helicopters, the jeers, and the distance between the balcony and the parade ground swallowed it. What reached posterity was not the speech but the photographs of the speaker—the raised fist, the headband, the white gloves—images in which the words are absent and only the gesture remains. Hladík's work was complete and invisible; Mishima's was visible and incomplete. In both cases the instant cannot be published.

10.6

The Speculative Moment

The works examined in this chapter share a structure that may be named the speculative moment, in the double sense of the word. The last instant is a *speculum*, a mirror in which image and reality are expected to coincide: the pavilion burning, the sailor dying at the height of his glory, the sun rising at the moment of the blade, the world ending in a sunset seen by a boy who will never see again. It is also a speculation, a hypothesis about what the instant will reveal, which cannot be verified because the one who experiences it cannot report it. Every such fiction therefore requires a witness—Honda, the kaishakunin, the boys around the drugged sailor, the reader—and every witness receives not the instant but its image.

The fictions know this. Isao's sun is an image; Komachi's beauty is a word; the blind youth's apocalypse is a memory; the sailor's glory is a taste of bitterness. The act of 1970 was an attempt to abolish the witness's distance, to make the instant public, to fill the speculative moment with

the real. The helicopters that rendered the speech inaudible were the historical form of the gap between instant and witness that the fictions had always inscribed, and the photographs that survived were the images that the fictions had always predicted would be all that remains.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Copy That Bleeds

Toward a Theory of Posthistorical Tragedy

11.1

1970: Two Suns, Two Shrines

The year of Mishima's death was the year of the Japan World Exposition at Osaka, which between March and September 1970 received some sixty-four million visits under the theme "Progress and Harmony for Mankind". At its centre stood Okamoto Tarō's Tower of the Sun, a monumental figure bearing three faces—a golden face of the future at its summit, a face of the present on its breast, and a black sun of the past on its back—together with a fourth, a sun of the underworld displayed in the exhibition beneath it and lost after the fair closed. The tower pierced the great space-frame roof that Tange Kenzō had designed for the Festival Plaza. Okamoto had spent the 1930s in Paris in the circle of Georges Bataille, and his later slogan, that art is explosion, condensed a Bataillean aesthetics of expenditure into a popular maxim. The Tower of the Sun is the solar economy of *La Part maudite* converted into a national festival: the surplus of a society at the height of its economic growth expended in spectacle. Mishima's sun, the sun of *Sun and Steel*, was the same Bataillean principle converted into a private sacrifice. In 1970 the nation chose the festival.

The Exposition was also the triumph of Metabolism, the movement launched at the World Design Conference in Tokyo in 1960 by Kikutake Kiyonori, Kurokawa Kishō, Maki Fumihiko, Ōtaka Masato, and the critic Kawazoe Noboru, under the tutelage of Tange. Its central idea was archi-

tecture as organic renewal: megastructures whose units could be replaced as the cells of a body are replaced. The connection with Ise was explicit. Tange and Kawazoe published a study of the shrine, *Ise: Nihon kenchiku no genkei* (1962; *Ise: Prototype of Japanese Architecture*, 1965), which presented the periodic reconstruction as the prototype of a modern architecture of cyclical replacement. Metabolism was a technocratic sengū. Its emblem, Kurokawa's Nakagin Capsule Tower (1972), was built of capsules designed to be replaced; none ever was, and the building was demolished in 2022. Isozaki Arata, the most searching architectural theorist of the generation, would later read Ise itself as a cycle that produces, retroactively, the origin it claims to repeat—a conclusion that coincides, from the side of architecture, with the verdict of the tetralogy's final page.

The year 1970 thus contained two shrines as well as two suns: a technocratic Ise, in which renewal is infrastructure, and a sacral Ise, in which renewal is sacrifice. Both failed in their literal forms. Yet the hypothesis they shared won a quieter victory. The sixtieth reconstruction of Ise took place in 1973, three years after Mishima's death, and the cycle has continued since, with the next rebuilding due in 2033. In 1994 the Nara Document on Authenticity, drafted by an international conference of heritage specialists, acknowledged that authenticity may reside not only in original material but in form, design, tradition, and technique, a revision widely explained by reference to the Japanese practice of periodic rebuilding. The sengū hypothesis entered international heritage doctrine a generation after its most extreme advocate had died attempting to prove it. It entered, however, as an administrative principle of conservation—as snobbery in Kojève's sense, the adherence to form without historical stakes—and not as the metaphysics of sacrifice for which Mishima had claimed it.

11.2

Simulacrum, Symbolic Exchange, and the Indiscernible

Three theoretical frameworks articulated in the decade around 1970 illuminate the reception of the act. Gilles Deleuze, in *Différence et répétition* (1968) and in "Platon et le simulacre" (1969), described Platonism as the enterprise of distinguishing good copies, icons that participate in the Idea by internal resemblance, from simulacra, phantasms that merely simulate resemblance; to overturn Platonism is to affirm the power of the simulacrum and to conceive repetition as the production of difference rather than the return of the same. The sengū hypothesis is a sacral Platonism in

which every rebuilt shrine, every emperor, and every incarnation is an icon of a single form. Tōru is its simulacrum, the copy whose resemblance is external only, and the final page of the tetralogy is the moment at which the Idea withdraws and every copy is revealed as a simulacrum. Deleuze would have greeted that moment as a liberation. Mishima's novel records it as desolation, and his act attempts to reverse it.

Jean Baudrillard's *L'Échange symbolique et la mort* (1976) argued that the modern order is founded on the exclusion of death from symbolic exchange, and that the only challenge the system cannot absorb is a gift that cannot be returned, above all the gift of one's own death. His later *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) described the precession of simulacra, in which the map precedes the territory—iconic anteriority at the scale of a civilisation. Read through the first book, Mishima's death is a symbolic gift offered to a nation that could not return it. Read through the second, it is an event received in a world where the image already precedes the real, and in which the gift is therefore absorbed as one more image. Baudrillard's two books are the two halves of posthistorical tragedy.

Arthur Danto's analysis of indiscernibles, from "The Artworld" (1964) to *The Transfiguration of the Commonplace* (1981), held that two objects perceptually identical may differ in their ontological status—one an artwork, the other a mere thing—by virtue of the interpretation that the institutions of art confer on them. Mishima had filmed his seppuku in *Yūkoku* and performed a samurai's suicide on screen in *Hitokiri*. The event of 1970 was, at the level of image, indiscernible from these representations; it differed from them only in being real, and reality is not a perceptual property. The public therefore had to decide into which category the event fell, and it chose between two frames, neither of which was the one Mishima had proposed. For the state, voiced in Prime Minister Satō Eisaku's reported verdict that Mishima must have lost his mind, the event fell outside meaning altogether. For the world of letters and images, it fell into the artworld as the last and most extreme of Mishima's works. In neither frame was it received as the political act of restoration it had declared itself to be. Roland Barthes had announced in 1967 the death of the author as the birth of the reader; Mishima literalised the figure in an attempt to fix his own meaning by dying, and the readers were born anyway.

11.3

The Savage, the Last Man, and the Magister

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) contains the most exact anticipation of the reception. John the Savage, whose sensibility has been formed by the complete works of Shakespeare—whose words, too, came before his flesh—flees the World State to a disused lighthouse, where he scourges himself in penance. The scene is filmed without his knowledge and released as a sensory entertainment; crowds arrive to watch him repeat it, the watching becomes an orgy, and the next morning he is found dead, having hanged himself. The copy that bleeds, in a posthistorical society, is received as entertainment, and the reception is the final blow. Nietzsche had named the inhabitant of such a society in the prologue to *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883): the last man, who has invented happiness and blinks (*»Wir haben das Glück erfunden« – sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln*). Kojève's posthistorical man is the last man described without contempt, and Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), which revived Kojève's argument for a new era, cited the Japanese note in which the gratuitous suicide appears as the purest act of posthistorical snobbery.

Hermann Hesse's *Das Glasperlenspiel* (1943) offers the counter-image. Its province of Castalia is a posthistorical order devoted to a game that synthesises all the contents of culture into combinations of pure form—a Bunka bōeiron realised as pedagogy. Its Magister Ludi, Josef Knecht, leaves the province to teach a single pupil in the world, and on his first morning of freedom, after watching the boy perform an ecstatic dance to the rising sun, follows him into an icy mountain lake and drowns. The death is unplanned and unwitnessed as spectacle; its only audience is the pupil, whom it transforms. Hesse's posthistorical tragedy is the death of the master of form at the threshold of the real, and its meaning is transmitted not as an image but as an obligation laid on one living person. It is the tragedy that Mishima's act could not be, because Mishima's act was designed to be seen.

11.4

Kojève Completed, Schopenhauer against Nietzsche

The act appeared to confirm Kojève's note with uncanny precision: a gratuitous suicide performed in a formalised mode by the most self-conscious aesthete of the nation that Kojève had called the labora-

tory of posthistory. Whether Mishima knew the note is undocumented, and the argument here is structural. Its conclusion is that the act did not refute Kojève by restoring history through a negating deed; it completed him. Mishima attempted to make snobbery bleed—to convert the formal suicide into a historical act by investing it with the full weight of the real—but in a posthistorical order every negation is received as a form, and the act entered the archive as the most perfect example of the very snobbery it had meant to transcend. Arnold Gehlen's theory of cultural crystallisation (1961), in which all the possibilities of a culture have been exhausted and only their recombination remains, and Lutz Niethammer's history of the idea of *posthistoire* (1989), describe the condition in which an act of breaking through is itself one of the permutations.

The double ending can now be read in its full philosophical grammar. The final page of the tetralogy speaks the language of Buddhist and Schopenhauerian negation: the will to identity is extinguished, and the garden holds nothing. The act speaks the language of Nietzschean and *Hagakure* affirmation: the will asserts itself unto death. Schopenhauer's §69 dissolves the apparent hierarchy between them. Suicide, he argued, affirms the will, because the suicide wills life and rejects only the conditions under which it has been given; the true negation of the will is the quieting of desire, not its violent consummation. By this measure the text is the radical negation and the act the conventional affirmation. Nietzsche's measure yields a parallel verdict. The highest affirmation, for Nietzsche, is *amor fati*, the willing of the eternal return of everything that has been, including what one most despises. Mishima could not will the return of the postwar Japan he described in July 1970 as inorganic and empty; the act was a refusal of recurrence, and in Nietzsche's terms a gesture of ressentiment against the present rather than its affirmation. Measured against both of the philosophers who shaped it, the act falls short of what the fiction achieves.

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1936) provides the final measure. Benjamin located the aura of the artwork in its unique existence in time and space, its historical testimony, and argued that technological reproduction dissolves it. The sengū hypothesis is a counter-theory of aura: it locates authenticity not in the unique object but in the ritual renewal of form, and it therefore promises an aura that survives, and is even produced by, reproduction. The tetralogy's final page concedes Benjamin's point. Without memory—without the historical testimony that Satoko declines to give—the chain of reproductions loses its aura, and the garden is the

place where aura is absent. Benjamin's epilogue diagnosed fascism's aestheticisation of politics in the formula *Fiat ars – pereat mundus*, and observed that humanity's self-alienation had reached the point at which it could experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order (*Ihre Selbstentfremdung hat jenen Grad erreicht, der sie ihre eigene Vernichtung als ästhetischen Genuß ersten Ranges erleben läßt*). Susan Sontag's "Fascinating Fascism" (1975) extended the diagnosis to the postwar consumption of fascist imagery. Both diagnoses apply to the act. What this thesis adds is that the same critique had already been formulated from within Mishima's own fiction, with a rigour that external critique has not surpassed. The constitutional questions that the manifesto of 1970 raised remain matters of legitimate democratic disagreement, on which this thesis takes no position; its critique concerns the aesthetic metaphysics that licensed violence against persons in the name of form.

11.5

Posthistorical Tragedy: A Definition

Posthistorical tragedy may now be defined by five conditions. First, the agent acts within an order whose historical negativity has been exhausted, so that no deed can be received as history in the making. Second, the act takes the form of a tragic sacrifice aimed at the restoration of an original—history, the sacred centre, the living god. Third, the agent knows, and has demonstrated in his own representations, that the act will be received as a replica of those representations. Fourth, the act is performed nonetheless, and its suffering is real: the copy bleeds. Fifth, the reception confirms the foreknowledge, and the act enters the archive as its own image.

The form inverts the classical structure at every point. In Aristotle's analysis the reversal of fortune precedes or coincides with the recognition; in posthistorical tragedy the recognition comes first, formulated in advance in the hero's own fiction, and the reversal follows as its execution. In Hegel's analysis tragedy is the collision of two ethical powers, each justified and each one-sided, resolved in a reconciliation that restores the ethical whole; in posthistorical tragedy the collision is between the act and its own replica, and no reconciliation is possible, only reception. Søren Kierkegaard's *Gjentagelsen* (*Repetition*, 1843) described the failure of its pseudonymous author to repeat a journey to Berlin and located genuine repetition only in the religious order, where Job receives everything double. The sengū hypothesis is a doctrine of repetition, and

the act of 1970 was an attempt to repeat the 2.26 officers, the Shinpūren, and Isao; the tetralogy had already concluded that such repetition yields only copies. The chorus of classical tragedy, which gave voice to the community's comprehension, is replaced by the rotor noise that made the speech inaudible. The copy that bleeds is the tragic object of posthistory: it bleeds, and it remains a copy.

11.6

The Site as Replica, and the Afterlives of the Act

The fate of the place confirms the fate of the event. When the Defence Agency moved its headquarters to Ichigaya at the end of the 1990s, the building in which the act took place was dismantled, and parts of it were re-erected as a memorial hall, among them the commanding general's office, whose door still bears the marks of the swords. The scene of the attempt to produce an original is now a reconstruction: a sengū of the site, visited as a monument to an event that was itself designed as one.

The literature that followed received the act exactly as the tetralogy had predicted. Murakami Haruki's *Hitsuji o meguru bōken* (*A Wild Sheep Chase*, 1982) opens on the afternoon of 25 November 1970, with Mishima's image repeating on a television whose sound has been turned off while the narrator and a young woman attend to other things: the act as a silent, looped image at the edge of attention, the precise form of its posthistorical reception. Ōe Kenzaburō had already, in "Sebuntiin" ("Seventeen", 1961) and its sequel, anatomised the ecstasy of a teenage right-wing assassin modelled on Yamaguchi Otoya, who on 12 October 1960 stabbed to death the chairman of the Japan Socialist Party, Asanuma Inejirō, on the stage of Hibiya Public Hall during a televised debate, and who three weeks later killed himself in juvenile detention, leaving on the wall of his cell the words shichishō hōkoku with an acclamation of the Emperor: Kusunoki's vow, which the Tatenokai would wear on its headbands a decade later. The sequel's withdrawal after threats demonstrated how dangerous such anatomy then was; in *Mizukara waga namida o nuguitamau hi* (*The Day He Himself Shall Wipe My Tears Away*, 1972) he answered Mishima's death with a parody of loyalist fantasy. The two Nobel lectures of the period frame the question: Kawabata's *Utsukushii Nihon no watashi* (1968), "Japan, the Beautiful, and Myself", and Ōe's *Aimai na Nihon no watashi* (1994), "Japan, the Ambiguous, and Myself", between which Mishima's corpus stands as the most rigorous attempt to make

beauty unambiguous, and the most rigorous demonstration that the attempt must fail.

Ōsawa Masachi's periodisation brackets the age of fiction between 1970 and 1995, and his analysis of the Aum Shinrikyō cult, whose members, on the orders of its leader Asahara Shōkō, released sarin on five Tokyo subway trains on 20 March 1995, killing thirteen people at the time (a fourteenth died of her injuries in 2020) and injuring thousands, in the name of an apocalyptic cosmology assembled from Buddhist vocabulary and the imagery of speculative fiction, presents that year as the terminal crisis of the period. The comparison is structural and not moral, and its point is a difference. Both events were attempts to make a fiction real through violence; but Mishima's fiction contained its own refutation, written in advance by its author, whereas the cult's cosmology contained none. Azuma Hiroki's account of the posthistorical subject as a consumer of recombinable images (2001) describes, finally, the circulation in which Mishima's poses now survive: the raised fist on the balcony, the Sebastian, the headband, detached from any argument and available for endless recombination. The act has become what the fiction said it would become. The only remaining question is whether the fiction can be read, against the image, as the more serious of the two endings—and that is the question to which the Conclusion returns.

CONCLUSION

The Garden at Noon

結

This thesis has read the works of Mishima Yukio as a single experiment on the ontology of form, conducted over a quarter of a century and concluded, on paper, before it was concluded in fact. *Kamen no kokuhaku* established its first premise, iconic anteriority: the image precedes the body, the word precedes the flesh, the mask precedes the face, and the imagined death of 1945 precedes the life that followed it. The genealogies of Part I supplied the further premises. From Nietzsche, Mann, the European decadence, and the Japan Romantic School came the conviction that form lives on the surface and that the surface is sustained only by the destruction of its bearers. From *Hagakure*, Yōmeigaku, Rinzai Zen, and Shintō nativism came the void that authorises action and the loyalist vow of rebirth. From Bataille and Sade came the economy of transgression and sovereign expenditure. Part II followed the premises into their structures: *Kinkakuji*, written in the presence of a replica, showed that the destruction of beauty issues in its reconstruction; *Sun and Steel* formulated the programme of thanatoplasty; *Bunka bōeiron* raised the sengū hypothesis to the level of sovereignty and made the Emperor the Ise of the nation. Part III followed the hypothesis into speculation. *Beautiful Star* loved humanity as a completed form visible only from beyond its end; *The Sea of Fertility* submitted the hypothesis to four trials and a single witness, and falsified it on its last page; the plays and shorter fictions analysed the last instant as a speculative moment that no witness can receive; and the act of 25 November 1970, read in the light of all that preceded it, emerged as the paradigm of posthistorical tragedy, a

tragic deed undertaken in full foreknowledge that it would be received as its own replica, and so received.

The argument makes three contributions. To Mishima studies it offers an inversion of the direction of explanation that has governed every major paradigm of the field. The works are not the prelude, symptom, or alibi of the death; they are its most exacting judge. The inversion restores to the fiction a philosophical seriousness that neither hagiography nor pathology has been able to credit, and it does so without admiring the act or dismissing the thought, since it locates the refutation of the act inside the thought itself. To the theory of speculative fiction it offers a method, speculative ontology, and a criterion drawn from Mishima's own reading of the *Tōno monogatari*: reality in fiction is certified not by the plausibility of its premise but by the charcoal scuttle, the minimal material consequence that converts a metaphysical proposition into fact. By this criterion *The Sea of Fertility* belongs among the major ontological fictions of the century, beside Lem, Bioy Casares, Borges, Le Guin, and Dick, and its distinctiveness can be stated precisely: it is a fiction in which a nativist hypothesis of transmission is tested by a Buddhist analysis of consciousness, and in which the analysis that grounds the novum is the instrument of its falsification. The ontological turn that McHale identified in postmodern fiction thus possesses a lineage outside the Euro-American canon, one in which metaphysical premises are not merely entertained but tried. To the ethics of aestheticised death, finally, the argument offers a model of critique from within. Benjamin, Sontag, and Maruyama supplied the external diagnosis of the aestheticisation of politics; Mishima's own fiction supplied an internal one, and it is more severe, because it grants every premise of the aesthetic it refutes and shows, on those premises alone, that the copy cannot become the original by bleeding.

The last page of the tetralogy is set at noon, and noon has a philosophical history. In *Also sprach Zarathustra* Nietzsche named the great noon (*der große Mittag*): the hour of the shortest shadow, at which humanity stands midway on its path and affirms the eternal return of all things. At the close of *L'Homme révolté* Camus invoked the thought of noon (*la pensée de midi*): the Mediterranean measure that recognises limits and refuses the absolute in whose name murder is committed. Mishima's garden at noon is neither. It affirms no return, since nothing in it returns; it counsels no measure, since there is nothing in it to measure. It is the vacant plot of Ise at the moment the cycle stops: a site cleared of its building, with nothing to be raised on it and no witness for whom the clearing means anything. Quentin Meillassoux has called the world as it is inde-

pendently of any consciousness that correlates it the great outdoors; the garden without memory is such an outdoors in miniature, the place at which the correlation between witness and world, on which the whole tetralogy had depended, is broken.

Yet the vacant plot at Ise is also the condition of every future building, and here the two endings of 25 November can be weighed against each other for the last time. The text leaves the garden empty and open. It concludes a lifetime's inquiry into form by refusing to fill the centre, and it hands to its reader, instead of a message, a place in which nothing has yet been decided. The act attempted to fill the same centre with a death and a manifesto, to convert the vacancy into a monument, and to fix its meaning by the most irrevocable means available. The act was received, as the fiction had predicted, as an image among images, and its meaning was appropriated by every party to its reception. The text, which claimed nothing, has kept its claim. Mishima's lasting contribution to the philosophy of literature is therefore not the deed he performed but the argument he wrote against it, with the full resources of his intelligence, before he performed it: a thought that knew its limit, inscribed in the same hand as a life that refused to know it.

The order of the two endings is the final datum of the thesis. The refutation was written first. The experiment was performed afterwards, and it returned the result the refutation had specified. A reader who takes that order seriously is asked to decide which of the two endings to inhabit, and this thesis has chosen the garden. It is summer there, and the sun stands at its height, where it casts the least shadow. The cicadas are loud. There is nothing in the garden—nothing, that is, except the light in which it can be seen that there is nothing there. It is from that nothing, and not from the balcony, that Mishima's work continues to speak.

Works Cited

WORKS BY MISHIMA YUKIO

Ketteiban Mishima Yukio zenshū. 42 vols. and supplements. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 2000–2006.

Hanazakari no mori. Serialised in *Bungei bunka*, 1941.

Tōzoku. 1948.

Kamen no kokuhaku. Tokyo: Kawade Shobō, 1949. Trans. Meredith Weatherby as *Confessions of a Mask*. New York: New Directions, 1958.

Ai no kawaki. 1950. Trans. Alfred H. Marks as *Thirst for Love*. New York: Knopf, 1969.

Kinjiki. 1951–1953. Trans. Alfred H. Marks as *Forbidden Colors*. New York: Knopf, 1968.

Aporo no sakazuki. Tokyo: Asahi Shinbunsha, 1952.

Shiosai. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1954. Trans. Meredith Weatherby as *The Sound of Waves*. New York: Knopf, 1956.

Kindai nōgakushū. 1956. Trans. Donald Keene as *Five Modern Nō Plays*. New York: Knopf, 1957.

Kinkakuji. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1956. Trans. Ivan Morris as *The Temple of the Golden Pavilion*. New York: Knopf, 1959.

Kyōko no ie. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1959.

Yoroboshi. 1960.

"Yūkoku." 1961. Trans. Geoffrey W. Sargent as "Patriotism." In *Death in Midsummer and Other Stories*. New York: New Directions, 1966.

Tōka no kiku. 1961.

Kurotokage. Stage adaptation of Edogawa Ranpo. 1961.

Utsukushii hoshi. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1962. Trans. Stephen Dodd as *Beautiful Star*. London: Penguin, 2022.

Gogo no eikō. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1963. Trans. John Nathan as *The Sailor Who Fell from Grace with the Sea*. New York: Knopf, 1965.

Watashi no henreki jidai. 1963.

"Mikumano mōde." 1965.

Sado kōshaku fujin. 1965. Trans. Donald Keene as *Madame de Sade*. New York: Grove Press, 1967.

Eirei no koe. Tokyo: Kawade Shobō Shinsha, 1966. Includes the essay "Nijūroku jiken to watashi."

Trans., with Ikeda Kōtarō. Gabriele D'Annunzio, *Sei Sebasuchan no junkyō*. Tokyo: Bijutsu Shuppansha, 1966.

Hagakure nyūmon. Tokyo: Kōbunsha, 1967. Trans. Kathryn Sparling as *The Way of the Samurai: Yukio Mishima on Hagakure in Modern Life*. New York: Basic Books, 1977.

Bunka bōeiron. *Chūō kōron*, July 1968. Book ed. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1969.

"Hashikawa Bunzō-shi e no kōkaijō." *Chūō kōron*, October 1968.

Waga tomo Hittorā. 1968. Trans. Hiroaki Sato as *My Friend Hitler*. In *My Friend Hitler and Other Plays of Yukio Mishima*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2002.

Taiyō to tetsu. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1968. Trans. John Bester as *Sun and Steel*. Tokyo: Kodansha International, 1970.

Haru no yuki. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1969. Trans. Michael Gallagher as *Spring Snow*. New York: Knopf, 1972.

Honba. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1969. Trans. Michael Gallagher as *Runaway Horses*. New York: Knopf, 1973.

"Kita Ikki ron." 1969.

With Tōdai Zenkyōtō. *Tōron: Bi to kyōdōtai to Tōdai tōsō*. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1969.

Akatsuki no tera. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1970. Trans. E. Dale Saunders and Cecilia Segawa Seigle as *The Temple of Dawn*. New York: Knopf, 1973.

"Hatashienai yakusoku: Watashi no naka no nijūgonen." *Sankei shinbun*, 7 July 1970.

"Kakumei tetsugaku to shite no Yōmeigaku." *Shokun!*, September 1970.

Geki. Manifesto, 25 November 1970.

Tennin gosui. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1971. Trans. Edward G. Seidensticker as *The Decay of the Angel*. New York: Knopf, 1974.

Shōsetsu to wa nani ka. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1972.

FILMS AND PHOTOGRAPHIC WORKS

Fukasaku Kinji, dir. *Kurotokage*. Shōchiku, 1968.

Gosha Hideo, dir. *Hitokiri*. Daiei, 1969.

Hosoe Eikō. *Barakei*. Tokyo: Shūeisha, 1963.

Masumura Yasuzō, dir. *Karakkaze yarō*. Daiei, 1960.

Mishima Yukio, dir. *Yūkoku*. 1966.

Schrader, Paul, dir. *Mishima: A Life in Four Chapters*. Warner Bros., 1985.

Shinoyama Kishin. *Otoko no shi*. Photographs, 1970.

Toyoshima Keisuke, dir. *Mishima Yukio vs Tōdai Zenkyōtō: 50-nenme no shinjitsu*. 2020.

OTHER PRIMARY SOURCES

Abe Kōbō. *Dai-yon kanpyōki*. 1959. Trans. E. Dale Saunders as *Inter Ice Age 4*. New York: Knopf, 1970.

Abe Kōbō. *Tanin no kao*. 1964. Trans. E. Dale Saunders as *The Face of Another*. New York: Knopf, 1966.

Akutagawa Ryūnosuke. "Jigokuhen." 1918.

Aristotle. *Poetics*.

Augustine. *Confessiones*. c. 397–400.

Ballard, J. G. *Crash*. London: Jonathan Cape, 1973.

Bioy Casares, Adolfo. *La invención de Morel*. Prologue by Jorge Luis Borges. Buenos Aires: Losada, 1940.

Borges, Jorge Luis. *Ficciones*. Buenos Aires: Sur, 1944. Includes "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius," "Las ruinas circulares," and "El milagro secreto."

Borges, Jorge Luis. *El Aleph*. Buenos Aires: Losada, 1949. Includes "El inmortal."

Burgess, Anthony. *A Clockwork Orange*. London: Heinemann, 1962.

Camus, Albert. *L'Étranger*. Paris: Gallimard, 1942.

Camus, Albert. *Les Justes*. First performed 1949. Paris: Gallimard, 1950.

Camus, Albert. *L'Homme révolté*. Paris: Gallimard, 1951.

Clarke, Arthur C. *Childhood's End*. New York: Ballantine, 1953.

Cocteau, Jean. *Les Enfants terribles*. Paris: Grasset, 1929.

D'Annunzio, Gabriele. *Il piacere*. Milan: Treves, 1889.

D'Annunzio, Gabriele. *Le Martyre de saint Sébastien*. Paris: Calmann-Lévy, 1911.

Dick, Philip K. *The Man in the High Castle*. New York: Putnam, 1962.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *Crime and Punishment*. 1866.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *Demons*. 1871–1872.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *The Brothers Karamazov*. 1880.

Edogawa Ranpo. *Kurotokage*. 1934.

Genshin. *Ōjōyōshū*. 985.

Golding, William. *Lord of the Flies*. London: Faber and Faber, 1954.

Hamamatsu Chūnagon monogatari. Eleventh century.

Hesse, Hermann. *Das Glasperlenspiel*. Zurich: Fretz & Wasmuth, 1943.

Hirata Atsutane. *Tama no mihashira*. 1813.

Huxley, Aldous. *Brave New World*. London: Chatto & Windus, 1932.

Huysmans, Joris-Karl. *À rebours*. Paris: Charpentier, 1884.

Kafka, Franz. *In der Strafkolonie*. Leipzig: Kurt Wolff, 1919.

Kamo no Mabuchi. *Niimanabi*. 1765.

Kawabata Yasunari. *Nemureru bijo*. 1961. Trans. Edward G. Seidensticker as *House of the Sleeping Beauties*. Tokyo: Kodansha International, 1969.

Kawabata Yasunari. *Utsukushii Nihon no watashi*. Nobel Lecture, 1968.

Komatsu Sakyō. *Nihon chinbotsu*. Tokyo: Kōbunsha, 1973.

Le Guin, Ursula K. *The Lathe of Heaven*. New York: Scribner, 1971.

Le Guin, Ursula K. "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas." In *New Dimensions 3*, edited by Robert Silverberg, 1973.

Lem, Stanisław. *Solaris*. Warsaw: Wydawnictwo MON, 1961.

Linji Yixuan. *Linji lu*. Ninth century.

Longus. *Daphnis and Chloe*.

Mann, Thomas. *Tonio Kröger*. 1903.

Mann, Thomas. *Der Tod in Venedig*. 1912.

Marinetti, F. T. "Fondazione e Manifesto del Futurismo." 1909.

Mauriac, François. *Thérèse Desqueyroux*. Paris: Grasset, 1927.

Motoori Norinaga. *Kojiki-den*. 1790–1822.

Mumonkan (*Wumenguan*). Compiled by Wumen Huikai, 1228.

Murakami Haruki. *Hitsuji o meguru bōken*. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1982. Trans. Alfred Birnbaum as *A Wild Sheep Chase*. Tokyo: Kodansha International, 1989.

Murakami Haruki. *Sekai no owari to hādoboirudo wandārando*. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 1985. Trans. Alfred Birnbaum as *Hard-Boiled Wonderland and the End of the World*. Tokyo: Kodansha International, 1991.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Die Geburt der Tragödie*. 1872.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Also sprach Zarathustra*. 1883–1885.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*. 2nd ed., 1887.

Ōe Kenzaburō. "Sebuntiin" and "Seiji shōnen shisu." *Bungakukai*, 1961.

Ōe Kenzaburō. *Mizukara waga namida o nuguitamau hi*. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1972.

Ōe Kenzaburō. *Aimai na Nihon no watashi*. Nobel Lecture, 1994.

Ōshio Heihachirō. *Senshindō sakki*. 1833.

Pirandello, Luigi. *Uno, nessuno e centomila*. Florence: Bemporad, 1926.

Plato. *Phaedrus*.

Proust, Marcel. *Le Temps retrouvé*. Paris: Gallimard, 1927.

Radiguet, Raymond. *Le Bal du comte d'Orgel*. Paris: Grasset, 1924.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. *Les Confessions*. 1782–1789.

Sade, D. A. F. de. *Justine*. 1791.

Sade, D. A. F. de. *Histoire de Juliette*. 1797–1801.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. "Érostrate." In *Le Mur*. Paris: Gallimard, 1939.

Schopenhauer, Arthur. *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung*. Leipzig: Brockhaus, 1819.

Shelley, Mary. *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. London: Lackington, 1818.

Stapledon, Olaf. *Last and First Men*. London: Methuen, 1930.

Stapledon, Olaf. *Star Maker*. London: Methuen, 1937.

Taiheiki. Fourteenth century.

Takuan Sōhō. *Fudōchi shinmyōroku*. Seventeenth century.

Tanizaki Jun'ichirō. "Shisei." 1910.

Tayama Katai. *Futon*. 1907.

Vasubandhu. *Triṃśikā-vijñaptimātratā*. Fourth to fifth century.

Vonnegut, Kurt. *Cat's Cradle*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1963.

Wagner, Richard. *Tristan und Isolde*. First performed Munich, 1865.

Wang Yangming. *Chuanxi lu*. 1518–1572.

Wilde, Oscar. *The Picture of Dorian Gray*. 1890. Rev. ed. London: Ward, Lock, 1891.

Wilde, Oscar. *Intentions*. London: Osgood, McIlvaine, 1891. Includes "The Decay of Lying" and "The Critic as Artist."

Wilde, Oscar. *Salomé*. Written 1891; published Paris, 1893.

Xuanzang. *Cheng weishi lun*. 659.

Yagyū Munenori. *Heihō kadensho*. 1632.

Yamamoto Tsunetomo. *Hagakure*. Recorded by Tashiro Tsuramoto, c. 1710–1716.

Yanagita Kunio. *Tōno monogatari*. 1910.

SECONDARY AND THEORETICAL SOURCES

Azuma Hiroki. *Dōbutsuka suru posutomodan*. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 2001. Trans. Jonathan E. Abel and Shion Kono as *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2009.

Barthes, Roland. "La mort de l'auteur." 1967.

Barthes, Roland. *L'Empire des signes*. Geneva: Skira, 1970.

Barthes, Roland. *La Chambre claire*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 1980.

Bataille, Georges. *La Part maudite*. Paris: Minuit, 1949.

Bataille, Georges. *L'Érotisme*. Paris: Minuit, 1957.

Baudrillard, Jean. *L'Échange symbolique et la mort*. Paris: Gallimard, 1976.

Baudrillard, Jean. *Simulacres et simulation*. Paris: Galilée, 1981.

Benedict, Ruth. *The Chrysanthemum and the Sword*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1946.

Benjamin, Walter. "Das Kunstwerk im Zeitalter seiner technischen Reproduzierbarkeit." 1936.

Butler, Judith. *Gender Trouble*. New York: Routledge, 1990.

Calichman, Richard F., ed. and trans. *Overcoming Modernity: Cultural Identity in Wartime Japan*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2008.

Danto, Arthur C. "The Artworld." *Journal of Philosophy* 61, no. 19 (1964): 571–584.

Danto, Arthur C. *The Transfiguration of the Commonplace*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1981.

Deleuze, Gilles. *Différence et répétition*. Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1968.

Deleuze, Gilles. *Logique du sens*. Paris: Minuit, 1969. Appendix: "Platon et le simulacre."

Derrida, Jacques. *De la grammatologie*. Paris: Minuit, 1967.

Doak, Kevin Michael. *Dreams of Difference: The Japan Romantic School and the Crisis of Modernity*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1994.

Flanagan, Damian. *Yukio Mishima*. London: Reaktion Books, 2014.

Fukuyama, Francis. *The End of History and the Last Man*. New York: Free Press, 1992.

Gehlen, Arnold. "Über kulturelle Kristallisation." 1961.

Harootunian, Harry. *Overcome by Modernity: History, Culture, and Community in Interwar Japan*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2000.

Hashikawa Bunzō. *Nihon rōmanha hihan josetsu*. Tokyo: Miraisha, 1960.

Hashikawa Bunzō. "Bi no ronri to seiji no ronri." *Chūō kōron*, September 1968.

Hegel, G. W. F. *Vorlesungen über die Ästhetik*. 1835–1838.

Heidegger, Martin. "Der Ursprung des Kunstwerkes." In *Holzwege*. Frankfurt am Main: Klostermann, 1950.

Hirano Keiichirō. *Mishima Yukio ron*. Tokyo: Shinchōsha, 2023.

Honjō Shigeru. *Honjō nikki*. Tokyo: Hara Shobō, 1967.

ICOMOS. *The Nara Document on Authenticity*. 1994.

Inose Naoki, with Hiroaki Sato. *Persona: A Biography of Yukio Mishima*. Berkeley: Stone Bridge Press, 2012.

Isozaki Arata. *Japan-ness in Architecture*. Trans. Sabu Kohso. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2006.

Jameson, Fredric. *Archaeologies of the Future*. London: Verso, 2005.

Jünger, Ernst. *In Stahlgewittern*. 1920.

Jünger, Ernst. *Über den Schmerz*. 1934.

Kantorowicz, Ernst H. *The King's Two Bodies: A Study in Mediaeval Political Theology*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957.

Karatani Kōjin. *Nihon kindai bungaku no kigen*. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1980. Trans. ed. Brett de Bary as *Origins of Modern Japanese Literature*. Durham: Duke University Press, 1993.

Keene, Donald. *Dawn to the West: Japanese Literature of the Modern Era; Fiction*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1984.

Kierkegaard, Søren. *Gjentagelsen*. Copenhagen, 1843.

Kojève, Alexandre. *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*. 2nd ed. Paris: Gallimard, 1962.

Lacan, Jacques. "Le stade du miroir comme formateur de la fonction du Je." 1949. In *Écrits*. Paris: Seuil, 1966.

Lacan, Jacques. *Le Séminaire, livre VII: L'éthique de la psychanalyse, 1959–1960*. Ed. Jacques-Alain Miller. Paris: Seuil, 1986.

Lifton, Robert Jay, Shūichi Katō, and Michael R. Reich. *Six Lives/Six Deaths: Portraits from Modern Japan*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979.

McHale, Brian. *Postmodernist Fiction*. New York: Methuen, 1987.

Maruyama Masao. "Chōkokkashugi no ronri to shinri." *Sekai*, May 1946.

Maruyama Masao. *Thought and Behaviour in Modern Japanese Politics*. Ed. Ivan Morris. London: Oxford University Press, 1963.

Meillassoux, Quentin. *Après la finitude*. Paris: Seuil, 2006.

Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Le Visible et l'invisible*. Paris: Gallimard, 1964.

Mita Munesuke. *Gendai Nihon no kankaku to shisō*. Tokyo: Kōdansha, 1995.

Miyoshi, Masao. *Accomplices of Silence: The Modern Japanese Novel*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1974.

Morris, Ivan. *The Nobility of Failure: Tragic Heroes in the History of Japan*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1975.

Napier, Susan J. *Escape from the Wasteland: Romanticism and Realism in the Fiction of Mishima Yukio and Ōe Kenzaburō*. Cambridge, MA: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard University, 1991.

Nathan, John. *Mishima: A Biography*. Boston: Little, Brown, 1974.

Niethammer, Lutz. *Posthistoire: Ist die Geschichte zu Ende?* Reinbek: Rowohlt, 1989. Trans. Patrick Camiller as *Posthistoire: Has History Come to an End?* London: Verso, 1992.

Nishitani Keiji. *Nihirizumu*. Tokyo: Kōbundō, 1949.

Nishitani Keiji. *Shūkyō to wa nani ka*. Tokyo: Sōbunsha, 1961. Trans. Jan Van Bragt as *Religion and Nothingness*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982.

Orikuchi Shinobu. "Daijōsai no hongi." 1928.

Ōsawa Masachi. *Kyokō no jidai no hate*. Tokyo: Chikuma Shobō, 1996.

Ōsawa Masachi. *Fukanōsei no jidai*. Tokyo: Iwanami Shoten, 2008.

Ōsawa Masachi. *Mishima Yukio: Futatsu no nazo*. Tokyo: Shūeisha, 2018.

Peirce, Charles Sanders. *Collected Papers*. Vol. 2. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1932.

Petersen, Gwenn Boardman. *The Moon in the Water: Understanding Tanizaki, Kawabata, and Mishima*. Honolulu: University Press of Hawaii, 1979.

Piven, Jerry S. *The Madness and Perversion of Yukio Mishima*. Westport, CT: Praeger, 2004.

Rankin, Andrew. *Mishima, Aesthetic Terrorist: An Intellectual Portrait*. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 2018.

Riviere, Joan. "Womanliness as a Masquerade." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 10 (1929): 303–313.

Rougemont, Denis de. *L'Amour et l'Occident*. Paris: Plon, 1939.

Schlegel, Friedrich. *Kritische Fragmente* and *Athenäums-Fragmente*. 1797–1798.

Scott Stokes, Henry. *The Life and Death of Yukio Mishima*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1974.

Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. *Epistemology of the Closet*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1990.

Shibusawa Tatsuhiko. *Sado kōshaku no shōgai*. Tokyo: Tōgensha, 1964.

Sontag, Susan. *Against Interpretation and Other Essays*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1966. Includes "Against Interpretation" and "Notes on 'Camp'" (both 1964).

Sontag, Susan. "Fascinating Fascism." *New York Review of Books*, 6 February 1975.

Starrs, Roy. *Deadly Dialectics: Sex, Violence and Nihilism in the World of Yukio Mishima*. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 1994.

Suvin, Darko. *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1979.

Suzuki, Daisetz T. *Zen and Japanese Culture*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1959.

Takayama Chogyū. “Biteki seikatsu o ronzu.” *Taiyō*, 1901.

Tange Kenzō and Kawazoe Noboru. *Ise: Nihon kenchiku no genkei*. Tokyo: Asahi Shinbunsha, 1962. English ed., *Ise: Prototype of Japanese Architecture*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1965.

Tansman, Alan. *The Aesthetics of Japanese Fascism*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2009.

Todorov, Tzvetan. *Introduction à la littérature fantastique*. Paris: Seuil, 1970.

Valéry, Paul. *L’Idée fixe*. Paris: Gallimard, 1932.

Victoria, Brian Daizen. *Zen at War*. New York: Weatherhill, 1997.

Vincent, J. Keith. *Two-Timing Modernity: Homosocial Narrative in Modern Japanese Fiction*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Asia Center, 2012.

Watsuji Tetsurō. *Nīchie kenkyū*. Tokyo: Uchida Rōkakuho, 1913.

Yasuda Yojūrō. *Nihon no hashi*. 1936.

Yourcenar, Marguerite. *Mishima ou la vision du vide*. Paris: Gallimard, 1980. Trans. Alberto Manguel as *Mishima: A Vision of the Void*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1986.

APPARATUS

Keywords

Mishima Yukio · *The Sea of Fertility* (*Hōjō no umi*) · sengū hypothesis · iconic anteriority · thanatoplasty · epitaphic humanism · speculative ontology · the copy that bleeds · posthistorical tragedy · Ise *shikinen sengū* · copy and original · authenticity · simulacrum · Yogācāra · *ālaya-vijñāna* · Hossō Buddhism · reincarnation · *Hagakure* · Yōmeigaku · Wang Yangming · Rinzai Zen · *kokugaku* · Shintō nativism · Japan Romantic School · Kyoto School · Overcoming Modernity · Emperor as cultural concept (*bunka gainen to shite no tennō*) · *kokutai* · empty centre · political theology · Humanity Declaration · 2.26 Incident · Kojève · end of history · *posthistoire* · snobbery · Nietzsche · Schopenhauer · Bataille · transgression · sovereignty · *Liebestod* · aestheticisation of politics · fascist aesthetics · Walter Benjamin · aura · Deleuze · Baudrillard · symbolic exchange · Danto · indiscernibles · Barthes · mask · confession · *shishōsetsu* · queer theory · the closet · masquerade · body and surface · *bunbu ryōdō* · *Sun and Steel* · *The Temple of the Golden Pavilion* · *Beautiful Star* · speculative fiction · science fiction theory · cognitive estrangement · the fantastic · ontological dominant · Lem · Bioy Casares · Borges · Philip K. Dick · Le Guin · Stapledon · Metabolism · Expo ‘70 · comparative literature · philosophy of literature · Japanese modernism · postwar Japan · 25 November 1970

Set in Lora, with Poppins for apparatus and Noto Serif CJK JP for the Japanese display characters. The cover sets a sun beside its copy; the back cover leaves the circle empty.





THE GARDEN AT NOON

THE COPY THAT BLEEDS